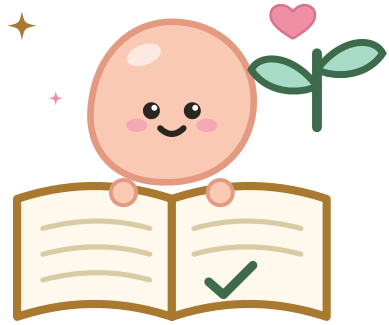
SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 1

Know Yourself Kindly

Where your lens came from, who you are now, and who you are becoming



by Christian

Christian's Lab
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance, Book 1: *Know Yourself Kindly*.
By Christian. Published by Christian's Lab, spreadloveandacceptance.com.

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Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com".

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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About this book, and how to use it

This book starts with you. It looks at where your way of seeing things came from, how you are wired today, how feelings work, why your worth was never a score, how personality works and how minds can work differently.

It is for anyone who wants to understand themselves a little better, at their own pace. You don't need a partner, a problem or a diagnosis to read it, and nothing in it is a test.

Read the chapters in any order. Each is a short version of a chapter that is free to read online, where the full version has more research, more examples and more to try. The code at the end of each chapter opens it on your phone.

HERE	ABOUT	FREE ONLINE AT SPREADLOVEANDACCEPTANCE.COM/BOOK
Chapter 1	Where your lens came from	…/book/self-1-then
Chapter 2	Your wiring, weather and words	…/book/self-2-now
Chapter 3	Who you are becoming	…/book/self-3-next
Chapter 4	How feelings work	…/book/understanding-1-feelings
Chapter 5	Self-worth, shame and self-compassion	…/book/understanding-7-worth
Chapter 6	Personality, temperament and change	…/book/understanding-14-personality
Chapter 7	Minds that work differently	…/book/understanding-9-minds

There are four books in the series, and each stands on its own. The others are Book 2, *Heal and Steady*, about the heavy days; Book 3, *Understanding Each Other*, about understanding the people around you; Book 4, *Share the Load*, about sharing the work of a shared life. When a chapter mentions another book, it gives the book, the chapter and the page in that book, as in "Book 2, Chapter 1 (page 9)". The workbook, The Workpapers, has every form from the series on big pages.

FIVE BIG IDEAS

Five ideas run under the whole series.

- **See the whole load.** Count the unseen work too, the noticing, remembering and planning, yours and other people's.
- **Fix the setup, not the person.** When something keeps going wrong, change the arrangement around it before you blame anyone.
- **Read your state first.** How full your day already is changes how every word sounds, so check yourself before you react.
- **Tune how you send and receive.** People differ in pace, tone and wiring, and a mismatch is something to translate, never a fault.
- **Notice the quiet incentives.** Jobs nobody owns drift to whoever notices first, and a named owner and a real thank-you stop the drift.

Some chapters mention the six-week program, a free plan on the website with one small step a week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01). The workbook has a planner for it. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on. Each line points to the chapter that helps most, and you can read that chapter on its own.

An old rule from home keeps steering you	Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from	9
Mornings, noise or crowds wear you out faster than other people	Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words	25
You want to change one habit or one part you play	Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming	47
Feelings arrive in your body before you can name them	Chapter 4 · How feelings work	63
A mistake turns into “I’m useless”	Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion	81
Your inner critic is loud	Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion	81
You and someone close are built very differently	Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change	99
You wonder whether your mind works differently	Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently	117
Fitting in all day leaves you drained	Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently	117

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-11 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as "Workpaper WP-11: The Calm-Down Kit". Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website, and the book gives a code to scan for each one. *The Workpapers: The Bound Edition* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as "Tool: How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz". You use it and it gives you something back.

Workpapers and tools are kept in separate lists. Both are free and need no account, and what you type stays on your own device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, a raindrop in a mortarboard, gives most of the hints, and answers questions on the website.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, points you at something to try.



Sugarfoot, the slower, steadier pup, turns up when a page needs a calmer pace.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

FROM THE PERSON WHO MADE THIS

> *"I spent my career as a government auditor and audit manager in tax enforcement, internal controls and compliance." "Everyone else seemed to have been handed a set of instructions about being human that nobody ever gave me, so I went looking for them myself." "Everything here exists so that you can do the same thing in far less time than it took me."*

Christian, quoted from the About page at spreadloveandacceptance.com/about. Where the chapters say "I", they speak for the website and these books; any fact about Christian in them comes from that page.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Book 3, Chapter 7, page 115 says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Book 2, Chapter 3, page 49 about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 1

Know yourself: then, where your lens came from

Why you expect what you expect, and how the rules you picked up growing up still make small decisions for you today.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. You're not one thing
2. Your lens came from somewhere
3. Each stage of growing up asks its own question
4. When something happened matters
5. Some old answers were learned without all the facts
6. An old rule can read other people for you
7. Write down the rulebook from home
8. You get to choose which rules to keep
9. What you carry forward is yours
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

SUNDAY, 10:15AM

Your partner is still in bed. The kitchen looks like a small storm went through it: last night's pan soaking on the hob, a tin of tomatoes open by the kettle, three mugs. Before you have had a single thought, you feel it. Of course it's always you. Nobody said that. But in the house you grew up in, whoever noticed the mess cleaned it, and that old rule has just made a decision on your behalf.

Across town, Ray's house has been quiet since his wife died, and nobody is going to see his dishes. He still can't sit down until every one of them is washed and dried and back in the

> *cupboard, because a rule from the home he grew up in is still keeping watch.*

01

You're not one thing.

A strong reaction usually comes from three places at once, and it helps to know which one is doing most of the talking. Part of it is how you're built, your wiring, which stays much the same through life. Part of it is what life taught you, the patterns that can soften with time. And part of it is just the kind of day you're having. This chapter is about the middle layer; Chapter 2 (page 25) takes the other two.

Dot, who is seventy-one, snaps at her son when he turns up forty minutes late for lunch with the roast already drying out. Some of that is wiring, because she has liked things on time since she was a girl. Some of it is an old rule, picked up from her own father, that being late means you don't care. And some of it is that she was awake at four listening to the wind. She could say, "Some of this is me being tired and some of it's an old thing. Give me a minute," and the lunch would probably recover.

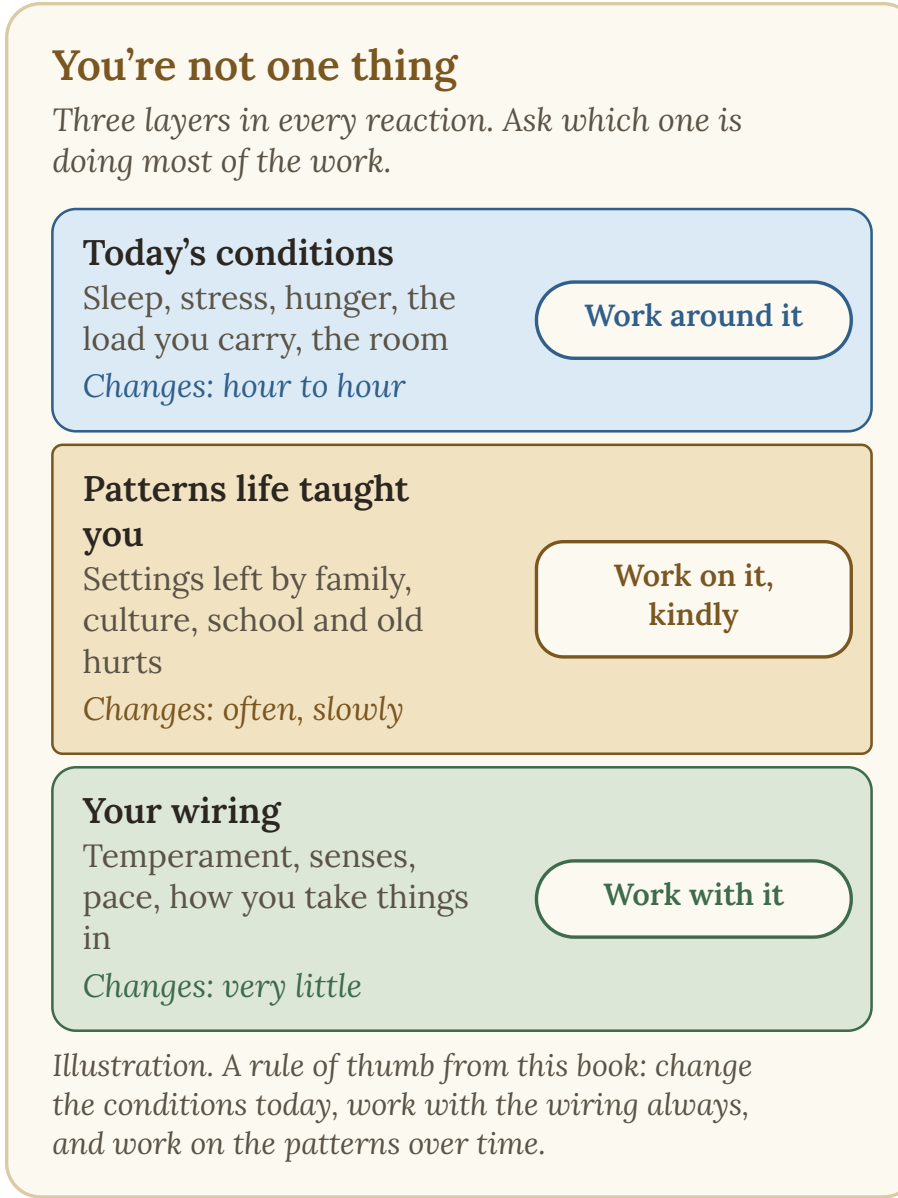


FIGURE 1 Three layers in every reaction. Each one changes at a different speed and needs a different move.

02

Your lens came from somewhere.

Family taught you what to expect of yourself and other people, and so did school, friends, culture, how much money there was at home and whatever was on the telly. By the time you're an adult the lens no longer feels like a lens. It feels like seeing.

Birthdays are a good test. One friend grew up with a party every year and cousins down from Glasgow; the other got a card on the breakfast table and a slightly better tea. A quiet dinner for two lands as a slight on one side of the table and as perfect on the other, and "In my family this was a big deal. What was it like in yours?" clears the air faster than any argument about what birthdays are for. Where your lens came from walks through the idea slowly, and you can read one section and stop.



TIDBIT

The rules from home aren't good or bad. They're just yours, and worth a proper look. How you like to talk is a good first one to look at.

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up



TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

03

Each stage of growing up asks its own question.

A small child is working out whether the world is safe and whether they can do things for themselves. Later the questions change to whether they're capable, where they belong, and whether they can be close to someone without losing themselves. Later still, adults start asking what they're building and whether any of it has meant something. The ages are rough, but the answer you landed on at each stop can become something you go on using for decades without noticing.

Someone who moved schools four times as a teenager may still walk into every new job feeling like the new kid with the wrong shoes, and only later realise that part of them never stopped asking whether they belong. Which of those questions still feels loud for you?

04

When something happened matters.

An experience tends to go deeper when it touches the question you were answering at the time. A house move at four is mostly about a new bedroom. A move at fourteen, right in the middle of working out where you belong, can leave a much longer feeling of being on the outside.

Two adult siblings remember their parents' divorce in ways that hardly overlap. The younger one was six and remembers a new bedroom with glow-in-the-dark stars on the ceiling and a different bus route. The older one was fifteen and remembers feeling torn in half every other Friday. Both memories are true, which goes a long way to explaining why they still argue about that year (see Family rifts, spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts). Deeper doesn't mean permanent, though; people keep learning all their lives.

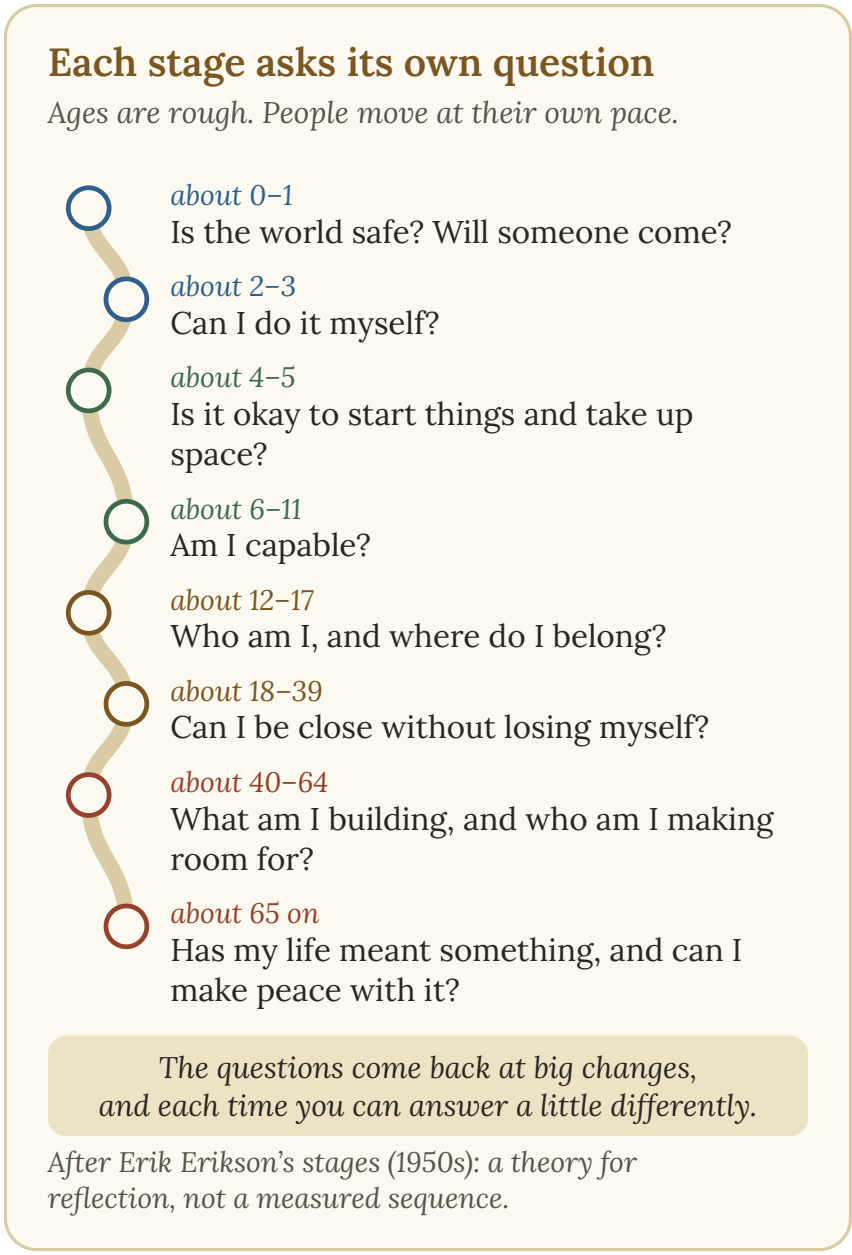


FIGURE 2 Each stage of life asks its own question. The ages are rough, and the questions come back at big changes (after Erik Erikson).

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/family-rifts

05

Some old answers were learned without all the facts.

Plenty of adults carry a sentence about themselves that they picked up before they could check it: “I’m only okay when I’m useful.” “My needs are a burden.” “Mistakes mean I’m bad.” A child can’t see what is going on for the grown-ups and only knows how it felt in the room. As an adult you’re allowed to look again with the full picture, which doesn’t mean deciding it was all fine.

Sheila has fostered children for eleven years and is very good at it. She learned as a girl that her needs were a nuisance, and so she finds it almost impossible to ask for respite, a planned weekend when someone else cares for the children, even in the week she put the cereal in the fridge. The old voice says don’t ask; the adult in her knows the service exists for exactly this. Write down one old belief about yourself, and underneath it write what you’d say to a friend who believed the same thing about themselves.

06

An old rule can read other people for you.

If silence at home meant someone was angry, a partner’s quiet evening can feel like weather coming in. And an expectation nobody ever said out loud can’t be agreed to, so the other person can only fail it, whether it’s “if you loved me, you’d just know” or

"whoever notices, does it". Every one of those is somebody's family rule.

A housemate heads out at ten past seven without saying goodbye, and someone raised in a quiet, angry house spends the morning wondering what they did, while the housemate is on the 7.14 to a shift she nearly overslept for. This week, when you catch yourself guessing what someone's silence means, try asking instead: "When you went quiet earlier I wasn't sure what it meant. Everything okay?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When an old rule jumps in before you've had a chance to think, you don't have to argue with it. Write it down, and look at it again on a calm day.

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

07

Write down the rulebook from home.

This is the exercise I'd do first if you only do one in this book. Finish these six lines the way your childhood home would have finished them. "In my family, love looked like…" "When someone was upset, we…" "The jobs were split like this…" "Resting was okay when…" "Asking for help meant…" "The unforgivable thing was…"

The rulebook page has room to write them, and nothing is saved anywhere except on your own device. Two partners from different faiths did this one December and both wrote that holidays belonged to their own family, which finally explained why every Christmas and every Eid had felt like a tug of war (see Two faiths, one family, spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths). One line today is plenty. If you share it with someone, you might say, "Here's a rule I grew up with. I'm not saying it's right. I just want you to know it's there."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The rulebook from home

Nadia, on her own

Your rulebook from home

Write a few words on each line, the way the home you grew up in would have finished it. Skip any line you like. Then, for each one, ask: do I still want this rule?

1. In my family, love looked like…
Doing things. Dad fixed your bike; nobody said it.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

2. When someone was upset, we…
Went quiet and waited for it to pass.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

3. The jobs were split like this…
Mum noticed, planned and remembered. Dad did the big jobs.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (*Drop*)

4. Resting was okay when…
Everything else was done.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften *Drop*

5. Asking for help meant…
You hadn't planned well enough.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften *Drop*

6. The unforgivable thing was…
Breaking a promise.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften Drop

Fill in your own: The rulebook from home

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
rulebook page
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

ONLINE
Two faiths, one family
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths

08

You get to choose which rules to keep.

Go back to your rulebook and ask of each line whether you still want it. When a reaction feels bigger than the moment, try a one-minute lens check once you've settled. Where did I learn this? How old does it feel? Is it true here, with this person, today? A team leader at a building society notices that her old rule about mistakes makes her hide problems from her manager until they're too big to hide. She writes a new one on a yellow sticky note above her monitor ("Mistakes are information, and the team fixes them

together") and leaves it there long after she stops needing it. Pick one rule from your list and write the version you'd like to live by: "I used to think ___. Now I'm choosing ___." Later, if you like, swap rulebooks with someone you trust and choose some shared rules on purpose.

09

What you carry forward is yours.

You couldn't control the home you grew up in, or what other people did, or what you learned before you had all the facts. What's in your hands now is smaller and a good deal stronger: which old rules you keep, how you treat yourself about them, and where you spend your energy today, and that includes people. Give your time and care where they're met with care. Where the effort is all one way, let it shrink back to what feels fair, so you still have something left over.

For nine years, someone who lives alone has organised every meet-up with an old school friend who never once asks back. They stop chasing, send one warm message ("I'd love to see you. Let me know when works for you") and find over the next few months that they see more of the friends who reply (see Always the one reaching out?). Is there a relationship where you give far more than comes back? You could give a little less there this month. (If you are afraid of someone, this isn't about managing them. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)



FIGURE 3 Where your lens came from, how you run today and who you are becoming, in one picture. You choose what you carry forward.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Always the one reaching out?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

TUESDAY MORNING

Two people get the same text from the same friend: "Can we talk tonight?" One is pleased, because she likes knowing what's coming. The other feels his stomach drop. In the house he grew up in, "we need to talk" meant trouble, and he spends the afternoon rehearsing answers in the car park and the queue at Greggs, for a conversation about splitting a cottage in Wales in August.

You, in all your relationships

Your old rules go wherever you go, starting with how you talk to yourself: the voice you use after a mistake is often an old one. At home they decide who notices, who plans and what quiet means, and two housemates can discover they've been living by different rulebooks about mess and who's allowed round after ten. In families, old roles like the helper or the peacemaker switch back on before you've got your coat off. At work, someone who was praised mainly for being useful may say yes to everything and then quietly resent it, until seeing the old rule lets them pause before the next yes. After a breakup old rules can get louder, which makes it a good time to look at them kindly (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). Help by relationship lists pages for many more situations.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

Common mix-ups

The biggest worry people bring to this chapter is that looking back means blaming their family. It's about understanding, and many of the adults who raised us were working with lenses of their own; if that doesn't fit your story, you don't have to make it fit. The second is that if something started in childhood you're stuck with it. Many old patterns soften once you can see them and feel safe enough to practise something new, and some leave a lasting sensitivity that you learn to carry and explain. People also assume every big reaction is an old wound, when quite often it's just a full tank (Book 4, Chapter 3, page 51, helps you tell leftover stress from this-moment stress). And some decide there's no point looking at their own rules if the other person won't look at theirs. I'd disagree. Knowing your own rules changes how you react, even if nobody else ever reads a word of this.

> **A note on care:** This part looks back at growing up. It is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy, and it can't tell you what anyone has. Not every home felt calm or kind, so take only what is useful. If looking back feels heavy, you can stop and come back another day, or explore it with a qualified professional, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared.

If you want to go on, think of one "always" or "never" you felt this week and ask whose voice it sounds like, and how old you felt when you heard it. Then write one sentence that the adult you would rather be could live by and stick it on the fridge. Where your lens came from, Roots & Wings and Know your own wiring go further.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

ONLINE
Know your own wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ You're not one thing.
- ✓ Each stage of growing up asks its own question.
- ✓ Some old answers were learned without all the facts.
- ✓ Write down the rulebook from home.
- ✓ What you carry forward is yours.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3, Chapter 3 · How we see each other
How a lens shapes what you notice in other people
Understanding Each Other, page 45

Book 3, Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging
How early trust and attachment carry into adult life
Understanding Each Other, page 61

Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change
Which parts are temperament, and which can change
page 99

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt
Making peace with what happened, and when to get help
Heal and Steady, page 85

PUT IT TO USE

The self path: see where your lens came from

spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then-in-depth

2

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 2

Know yourself: now, your wiring, your weather and your words

Why the same words can land differently on different days and in different people, and how to understand today's you well enough to say what helps.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Today is made of two layers you can work with
2. Know how you like to be spoken to
3. Check your weather before you speak
4. Ask where this feeling is coming from
5. Plan what settles you on a calm day
6. Your needs and limits are information, not demands
7. Being wired differently is not being wrong
8. Explain yourself without over-sharing
9. Do your part, and only your part
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

SUNDAY, 7:50PM

"You okay? You've been quiet all day." Your friend has paused the film to ask. You say you're fine. The honest answer is that you can't tell whether you're fine, tired or quietly bothered by something someone said on Thursday, and you couldn't explain it to yourself, let alone to her, so you press play.

01

Today is made of two layers you can work with.

Your wiring is the lasting part: your temperament, your pace, your senses, how you take in words. You work *with* it, by building a setup that suits you. Today's conditions are the passing part, things like sleep and hunger and the time of day, and you work *around* them by eating first or sleeping on it. A lot of frustration comes from mixing the two up. (Chapter 1, page 9, covers the third layer, the patterns life taught you.)

A dad who works nights finds the school-run chatter unbearable at ten past eight in the morning, and for a few months he quietly wonders whether he's cut out for parenting at all. Then he swaps with his partner and does the half-three pick-up instead, and the same chatter about who sat next to whom at lunch is funny again (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours). The children hadn't changed. The hour had. Write down one thing that always bothers you, which is probably wiring, and one that only bothers you when you're tired.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "It's the hour, honestly. Can we talk after I've slept?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your wiring stays the same from day to day. Your weather doesn't. A one-minute check in the morning helps you tell the two apart.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours



TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

02

Know how you like to be spoken to.

Pace, tone, how much you need spelled out, what a silence means to you: they all change how words land. How you connect helps you find words for how you take things in and give them out, and it gives you a four-letter Wave Code, which is meant to be light-hearted, so please don't put it on your CV. The "How to talk to me" card puts how you take in words on one page you can hand over before a hard talk.

Agnes, who is seventy-two, loves a phone call. Her grandson Jago loves a text. For about a year each of them privately decided the other had gone a bit distant, until a cousin pointed out the obvious over a Christmas trifle, and now there's a Sunday call at six with texts in between. If you want somewhere to start, finish the sentence "I take things in best when…" and keep it for your card.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

"How to talk to me" card
Ife, made on her own to give to a friend

Your card

Pick what is usually true for you. Add a few words where the

buttons are not enough. Leave a line blank if it does not apply.

Who it's for

A partner Family *A friend* Work (a manager or coworker)

Name on the card, optional

Ife

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
In writing. One thing at a time.

I take words
Literally when it matters, tone when it is light.

Give me time to answer
A few minutes.

If I go quiet, it means
I'm thinking.

Please avoid
Long texts or many topics at once.

A request lands best as
The ask in the first sentence.

Applies more strictly when I am running low. Not a contract, and not a label. Change it when it stops being true.

Fill in your own: "How to talk to me" card

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

03

Check your weather before you speak.

Every conversation runs through your own state before it reaches anyone else. Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51) looks closely at the stress tank in a shared home, so all this chapter adds is the self side: a one-minute reading on your own before you decide what a hard moment means. My weather today is the quick check, and How much are you carrying? is a fuller one on a short worksheet.

A long-distance couple notice that every difficult call falls at the end of one partner's late shift, around midnight her time, so they move serious talks to Saturday mornings with coffee (see Long distance, spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "I'm running on empty tonight. Can we pick this up tomorrow morning?"

ONE STATE, MANY WORDS. The chapters and tools use a few everyday pictures for one thing, how much room you have today.

- **The three states** (Book 2, Chapter 1, page 9, calls them the ladder) are calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty.
- **My weather today** uses sky words for the same three. *Clear* is calm and connected, *gusty* is revved up, and *fogged in* is running on empty. Its *pressure* is how much you were already carrying.
- **The stress tank** is the score from How much are you carrying?, from 0 to 1, where higher means fuller.
- **The battery** is the other side of the tank, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery.

"Gusty", "revved up", "a fairly full tank" and "a low battery" can all describe the same Tuesday afternoon. I'd pick one set and stick with it.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks



ONLINE
Long distance
spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance

04

Ask where this feeling is coming from.

Name the feeling first, even roughly (“tight, annoyed, a bit scared”). Then ask whether it’s the size of the moment or feels older, which layer it belongs to, and what it needs right now. Food, space, a heads-up, some reassurance, a proper conversation later: the answer is often more ordinary than you’d expect. It takes a minute and works best once the first wave has passed. A colleague leans over the partition at 4.45 on a Friday and says “Quick question?”, your heart starts going, and if you stop to look you might find it’s jumpy, with a former boss somewhere in it and a long week on top, and that what it needs is five minutes before you answer.

When feelings are hard to name. For some people, “What are you feeling?” is a hard question most days and nearly impossible on bad ones. They notice a racing heart or a heavy stomach and can’t tell whether it’s worry or hunger, or something else entirely. Psychologists call this *alexithymia*, which means “no words for feelings”. It’s a trait that runs from a little to a lot, it’s common, especially among autistic people, and it isn’t an illness. The feelings are there and the words come slowly. Start with the body (“tight chest, skipped lunch”). Choose between two words rather than finding one from scratch (“more tired or more annoyed?”). Use the sky words if feeling words won’t come, and give it time. “I’ll tell you tomorrow” is a real answer.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

My weather today

Joel, on his own, after a short night

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · Coworkers · Someone I care for · Friends · *Mostly on my own*

The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · Running on caffeine · Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · *Short night* · About enough · Properly rested

People load

Barely any · A normal amount · *A lot* · Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · One conversation · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · *Food or water* · Rest · *To move* · To be heard · A plan · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Pace
go gently, settle first

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for big decisions.

You said what would help is food or water and to move. Arrange that before anything else.

Overall: some room today. There is less room than usual, so spend it carefully.

If you want to send someone a line: "I'm a bit wound up today, so I'll keep replies short. It isn't about you."

Fill in your own: My weather today

05

Plan what settles you on a calm day.

The middle of being wound up is a terrible time to work out what helps you calm down. The Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make while you're calm: what tends to set you off, two calming steps, and one sentence for stepping away that says when you'll be back. It's for you. It is never a list of instructions for the other person.

Fourteen-year-old Elsie makes one for the rows she has with her mum about her phone. The next time a row heats up, she says, "I need ten minutes in my room, then I'll come back," goes upstairs, lies on her bed with her headphones in, and twelve minutes later comes back down to the kitchen, where her mum has put the kettle on. On a calm day, write your one stepping-away sentence, with the coming-back time in it.

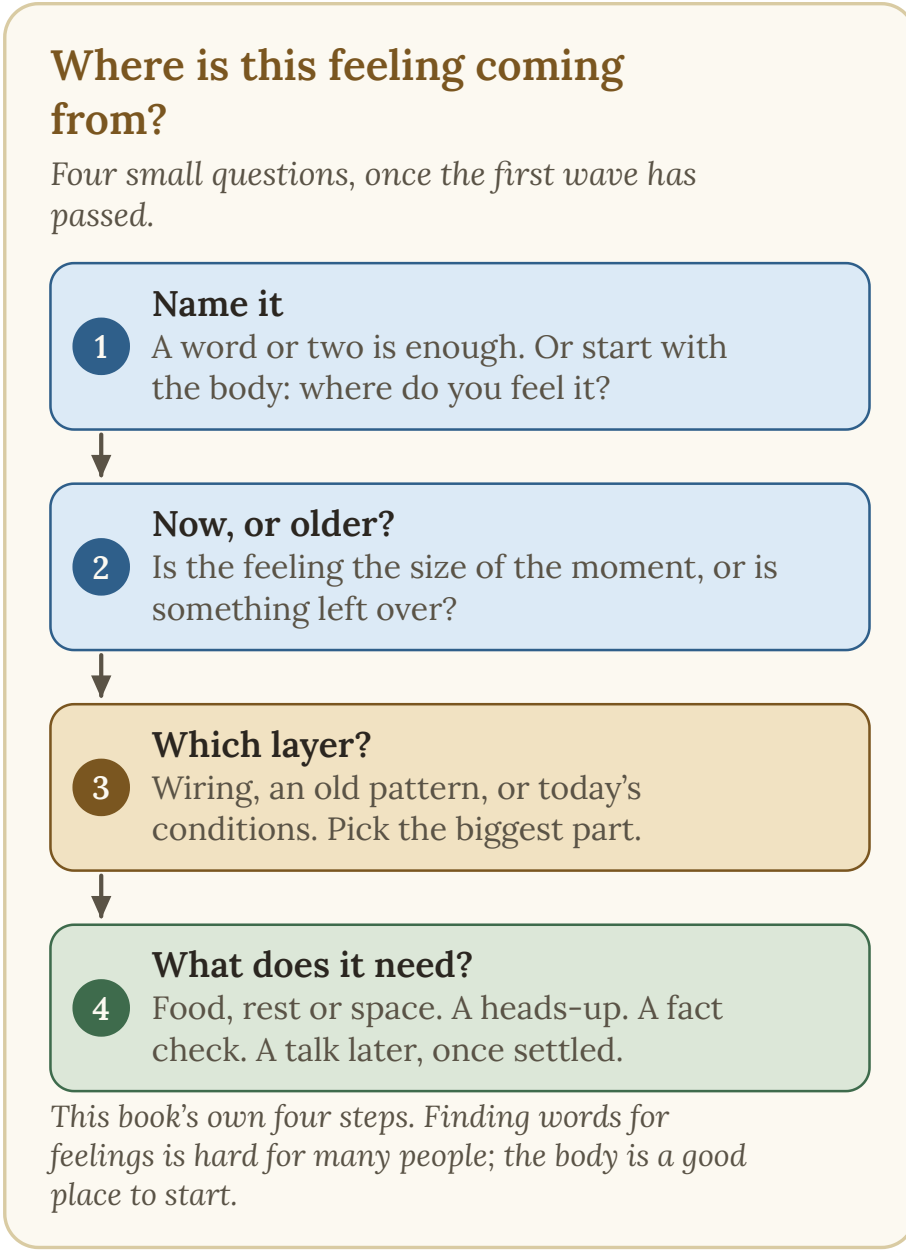


FIGURE 4 A four-step self-check for a feeling that is bigger than you expected. Do it once the first wave has passed.



SUGARFOOT

Make your calm-down plan on a slow, quiet day, with a cup of tea if you like. It's far easier than making one in the middle of a storm.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

06

Your needs and limits are information, not demands.

What helps you, what matters to you and what you've got left are facts about you, and said kindly they let other people plan around you. "A heads-up helps me." "I can take this one, but not that one." "I'm low today. Can we talk tomorrow?" You don't have to justify a need. A reason is a kindness you can offer when you want to.

Quinn lives with his two partners in a terraced house with one bathroom and a lot of shoes in the hall. He needs an hour alone after work, and once he has said so, calmly, it stops being a mystery and becomes part of the plan, like bin day. Two workpapers from other chapters can help with the words: Who did what, from Book 4, Chapter 1 (page 9), has ready-made kind ways to say no, and Say it so it lands, from Book 4, Chapter 4 (page 73), turns a raw reaction into a plain request. Try writing one need you've never said out loud, and say it to the mirror as a fact, without the apology on the front.

07

Being wired differently is not being wrong.

Some people take in words, noise, change and feelings differently from the way most social customs were built. That's wiring, which you can understand, plan around and get support for if you choose to. A woman with ADHD keeps forgetting plans with a friend and has been calling herself hopeless for years. Now she tells her friends the one thing that helps, a text the day before, and she turns up (see Neurodivergent relationships, spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships).

A mix-up runs both ways. When an autistic and a non-autistic person misread each other, the autistic person usually gets the blame. The *double empathy problem*, named by the autistic researcher Damian Milton, is the idea that the gap runs both ways: each person reads the other through their own way of communicating, and each finds the other hard to read. In one study, a story passed along a chain of autistic people kept as much detail as one passed along non-autistic people, while mixed chains lost detail faster. I find that study quietly cheering. Wired Differently shows how two differently wired people can each misread the other, and "Where did we lose each other?" lets both of you adjust a little.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
Wired Differently
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently

08

Explain yourself without over-sharing.

Most moments need one of three short sentences. “This is how I’m wired. It won’t change, but here’s what helps.” “This is an old alarm. I’m working on it, and here’s what helps in the moment.” “Today’s a low-battery day.” You never owe anyone your history. Share the part that helps them help you. A man with a long-term illness tells a new friend from the climbing wall, “Some days I have less energy, and if I cancel, it isn’t about you,” and leaves his medical notes out of it (see When one of you is ill, spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
When one of you is ill
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill

09

Do your part, and only your part.

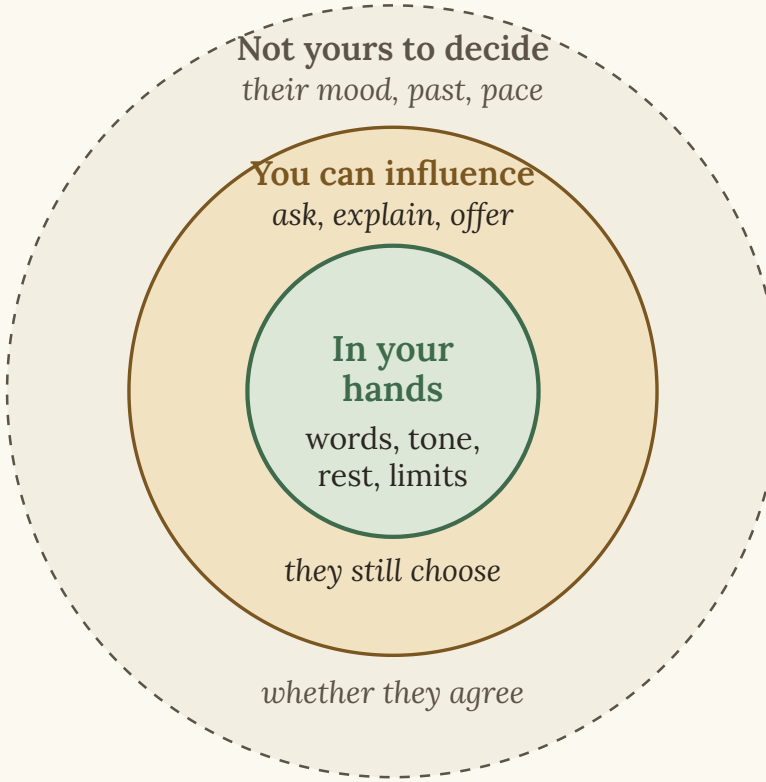
Today you control your words, your effort, your rest, your limits and what you ask for. You don’t control anyone else’s mood or reply or pace, and trying to manage them will drain you faster than almost anything. It also helps to match energy with energy, meeting warmth with warmth, and giving a little less where you keep giving far more than comes back. A protected battery is what keeps you kind.

A grown-up daughter has spent years trying to stop her father worrying about her. She can’t. What she can do is send “Home safe x” after long drives on the M6 and then let his worry be his (see For grown-up children, spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children).

Write one thing you keep trying to control that isn't yours, and next to it one thing that is. (If you are afraid of someone, this isn't about managing them. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)

Your circle of control

Spend your energy from the middle out.



Most exhaustion comes from pouring energy into the outer ring.

Illustration.

FIGURE 5 Your circle of control. Spend your energy from the middle out; most exhaustion comes from pouring it into the outer ring.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
For grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

FRIDAY, 6:40PM

"Surprise! I've booked us dinner with my cousins tonight. Half seven at the Turkish place." They meant it as a gift. You felt your chest tighten and heard yourself say "Great" in a voice so flat it could have been ironed. Later, at the sink, you wonder whether that was just you, something from years ago or the end of a long week. Probably some of each, and you still haven't said anything.

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Leaving early without a long goodbye

FROM OUTSIDE Partway through a party, someone slips out with a quick wave.

THE LOGIC Energy works like a budget → This evening spent it faster than expected → Staying past empty risks a shutdown or a sharp word → Leaving quietly protects the evening and the friendship

IT'S LIKE A phone on 3% that switches off everything except the call.

WHY IT FITS A long goodbye costs energy too, and there is very little left by then.

THE OTHER SIDE The host may wonder what went wrong, or whether you had a bad time.

YOU COULD SAY *"I had a good time. When my battery goes, I need to go quickly."*

ONE SMALL STEP Send a short thank-you text the next morning.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=left-party

You, in all your relationships

Your wiring and your weather come with you everywhere, starting with how you treat yourself on a hard day, when noticing that you're low ought to come before deciding that you're failing. Partners can give each other a heads-up or a quiet hour, and every partner has wiring of their own. With friends and family the question is often how you like to keep in touch and how much you can give this month. At work it may be an agenda the day before, or a minute before you answer. Housemates mostly negotiate noise, and who gets the bathroom first. If you live on your own, you get to build a week that suits how you're built (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

A few come up again and again. Knowing yourself is mostly about what helps. A label can come later, or never, and the three layers and a Wave Code are everyday words with no diagnosis in them. "That's just how I am" may well be true, especially about wiring, but it works far better as the start of a conversation ("This is how I'm wired, and here's what helps") than as the end of one. Telling people how you're wired doesn't mean they now have to manage you. It helps their words land, and you still do your part while they still have needs of their own.

And "I'm fine" sometimes means fine. It can also mean you've been tired for so long you stopped noticing. A quick reading once a week shows you the baseline you've got used to, which is sometimes a surprise.

A note on care: This part is general education. It isn't a diagnosis, a test or treatment, and it can't tell you whether you're autistic, have ADHD or anything else, or what anyone else has. If you'd like to understand yourself more deeply, a qualified professional can help, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you try needs to be shared. If talking about any of this with someone ever feels unsafe, or you feel you can't say no, stop and talk with a trained counselor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counseling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

To put the chapter to use, pick one reaction you had this week and write a line for each layer: the wiring part, the older part, today's part. Take a one-minute reading of your weather. Then write one sentence about what helps you, in your own words, and keep it to yourself for a few days before you try it out on one person on a calm day. Know your own wiring, the "How to talk to me" card and How much are you carrying? are free on the site.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety



ONLINE
Know your own wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself



TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card



WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Today is made of two layers you can work with.
- ✓ Check your weather before you speak.
- ✓ Plan what settles you on a calm day.
- ✓ Being wired differently is not being wrong.
- ✓ Do your part, and only your part.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently
Wiring differences: autism, ADHD and the senses
page 117

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system
Why your weather changes how you hear things
Heal and Steady, page 9

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
The stress tank, used between two people
Share the Load, page 51

Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair
What fair means when you share the work
Share the Load, page 73

PUT IT TO USE

The self path: get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

How much are you carrying? A quick stress check
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth

3

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 3

Know yourself: next, shaping who you are becoming

You aren't finished, and some of who you become is up to you. This chapter is about choosing a direction and building small steps that still work on a tired day.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Start with what matters to you
2. Pick one small goal, in plain words
3. Name what gets in the way
4. Make the step tiny, and repeatable
5. Decide ahead with a simple if-then
6. Ask for support, as information
7. Look back kindly once a month
8. Kindness to yourself is part of the plan
9. Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

WEDNESDAY, 9:10PM

You meant to start walking after dinner. You meant to last week too. Tonight you're tired, the trainers are still by the door where you left them on Sunday with the laces tucked in, ready, and you tell yourself you'll begin on Monday, which has a nice clean feel to it.

01

Start with what matters to you.

A goal built on someone else's idea of success is very hard to keep up. So before you pick anything, ask what you want your days to be like, and write two or three plain words: calm, say, or close to my

family, or steady, or creative. They give you a direction to face rather than a score to hit. How you connect can help you notice what fills you up and what drains you, if you're not sure.

After their youngest leaves for university, a couple each write two words on the back of an envelope. Hers are "useful, outdoors". His are "calm, curious". It suddenly explains why she has been eyeing the volunteers' hut at the nature reserve while he keeps wandering down the garden to look at the vegetable patch (see Kids grown and gone, spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest). Write your two in pencil, since you're allowed to change them.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength



ONLINE
Kids grown and gone
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest

02

Pick one small goal, in plain words.

Just one, said as something you'll do. "Walk for ten minutes after dinner" is a goal you can keep. "Get healthier" is a hope, and hopes are lovely but you can't put them in a diary. Your own actions are up to you; how other people respond, and how things turn out, aren't. A student sharing a room in halls wants to be "less messy", and turned into an action it becomes putting her clothes in the basket before bed (see Sharing a room, spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room). Try rewriting one wish so it starts with "I will…"

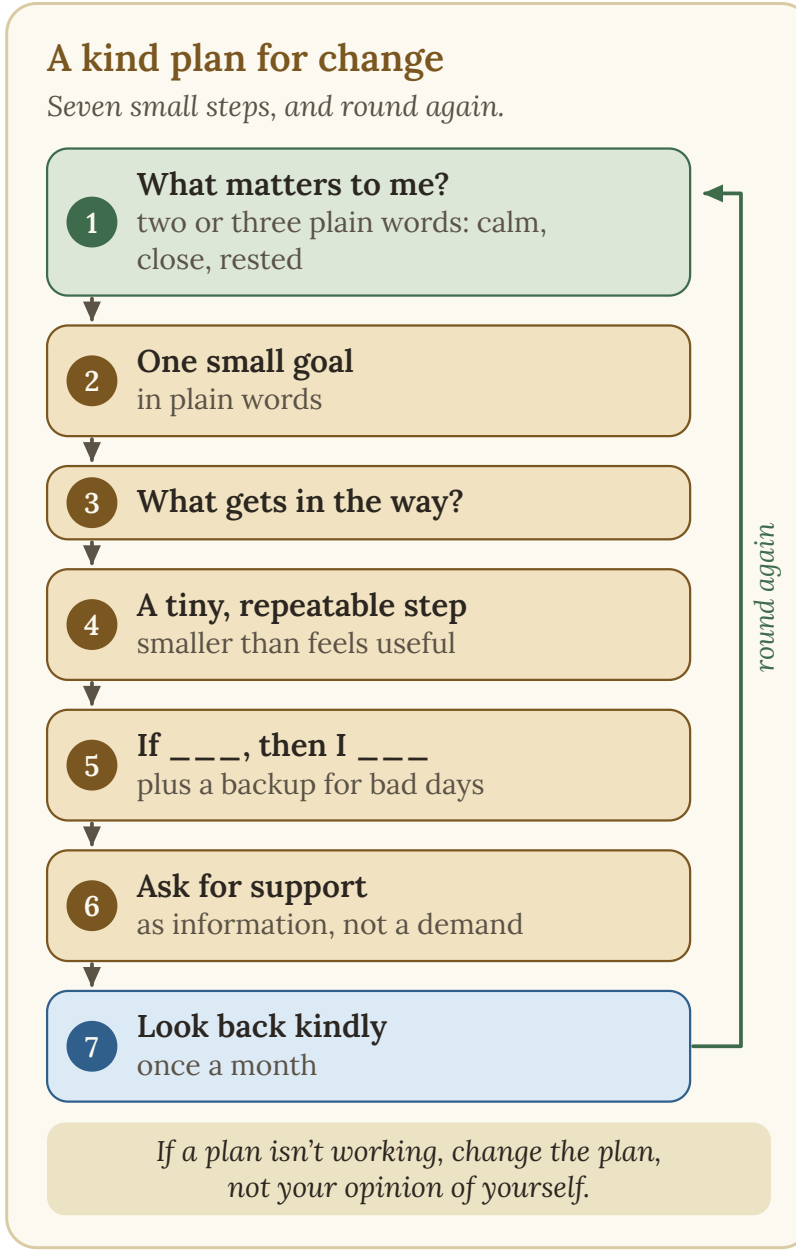


FIGURE 6 A kind plan for change in seven small steps. If the plan isn't working, change the plan, not your opinion of yourself.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

03

Name what gets in the way.

This is where Chapter 1 (page 9) and Chapter 2 (page 25) earn their keep. The obstacle might be your wiring, and a plan that ignores how you're built was really made for someone else. It might be an old rule, such as "rest has to be earned". Or it might just be a tired Tuesday. Whichever it is, change the arrangement and leave yourself alone.

A warehouse worker kept missing his evening run and had more or less decided he was lazy. He wasn't. His rota changed every week, so "evenings" meant something different every Monday. Once he tied the run to his first day off, whenever that fell, he stopped missing it (see Different hours, spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours

04

Make the step tiny, and repeatable.

Small enough to survive your worst week. “Put my shoes on” counts, and I mean that. Tie it to something you already do, and do it often. The 90-second daily check-in in Book 3, Chapter 1 (page 9) runs on the same idea, that small and frequent outlasts big and rare, and Ten-minute start shows how small a whole path can be.

Someone on their own after a breakup wants to “get back out there”, which is far too big to start on a Sunday night. The step they choose is one message to one friend every Sunday, usually sent from the sofa during the weather forecast (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). If your step takes more than two minutes, shrink it again.



TIDBIT

Tiny steps count, wobbly ones included. If you like a game, there’s one where each small kind act moves the ball up the field.

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Ten-minute start
spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

TOOL
Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

05

Decide ahead with a simple if-then.

"If it's after dinner, then I put my shoes on." Deciding ahead means one decision fewer on a tired day, which is the same thinking as the Calm-Down Kit, made while you're calm. A separated parent who wants calmer handovers decides that when she pulls up outside her ex's house, she'll take three slow breaths with the engine off before she gets out (see Co-parenting, spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting). Pick a cue that happens every day anyway, like the kettle or the front door or brushing your teeth, and if the if-then isn't working, change it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

The Calm-Down Kit, just for me

Nell, on her own

The Calm-Down Kit

Your name
Nell

Date
11 October 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
A long message from my sister late at night	*Tight chest, typing fast*
Plans changed with no warning	*Jaw, hot face*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Walking it out

Second, if the first isn't available
Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm at capacity. I'm going to step away for twenty minutes, and I'll answer properly after that.

My pause plan (yours to share, if you like)

My pause word or signal
"Back in a bit"

The shortest break I take
20 minutes

How I set the time to come back
I text a time, the same day

The first sentence when I come back
"Thanks for waiting. I can think straight now."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
9:40 pm	*Walking it out*	*Still hot*
10:05 pm	*Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next
Settled enough: pick things back up, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
Reply to my sister's message, one line

If you put it off: when you'll pick it back up
Tomorrow after lunch

☑ I'm going with this
Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (Just me)

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11



TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

06

Ask for support, as information.

Tell one person what you're trying and what would help. "I'm trying to walk after dinner. Could you ask me how it's going on Sunday?" They can say no, and you don't need anyone's agreement to start.

Since her husband's stroke, Glenys has done almost all his care. She asks her brother whether he could sit with him on Thursday afternoons from two till four so she can go swimming. Because the request is so specific, it's easy for him to say yes, and he does, and he brings biscuits. Some goals are better shared with a qualified professional, and asking for one is a sensible step whenever you want it. (If someone uses your goals to check up on you or control you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

07

Look back kindly once a month.

This is the monthly look-back from Book 4, Chapter 5 (page 95), pointed at yourself instead of a household. Once a month, take ten minutes to ask what went well, what kept slipping, and whether the gap was in the plan, in how much you had to give that month or in one strange week. Old misses don't get added up. The only question is what to try next month.

A grandmother raising her two grandchildren sits down with a cup of tea on the first of March and sees that bedtime is working and homework very much isn't. So in March she tries homework at the kitchen table straight after a snack, before the telly goes on. Put ten minutes in your calendar for the first of next month now, while you're thinking of it.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your monthly look is the solo version of the monthly look-back for people who share a home. Borrow its two questions if you like: what kept slipping, and what would have made it easier?

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · free to print · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

08

Kindness to yourself is part of the plan.

There's an old image of the second arrow that I find useful here. The first arrow is the slip itself. The second is the telling-off you give yourself afterwards, which hurts more and helps less, and a plan that needs you to be harsh with yourself is mostly second arrows. Rest belongs inside the plan, and you can shrink a goal or drop it whenever you like.

A sixteen-year-old who planned to revise every night misses three nights running and announces at breakfast that he's useless. His grandmother, buttering toast, asks what he'd tell his best friend if it were him. He thinks about it, rolls his eyes, and shrinks the goal to twenty minutes before tea. Next time you miss a step, say one sentence to yourself that you'd say to a friend.

09

Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

A goal that depends on someone else changing is really a wish. Shape each one around what you can do, such as asking once, kindly, by Friday. You might wish your grown-up sister rang more often; that's outside your circle. Ringing her on the first Sunday of each month, and telling her you'd love her to ring too, is inside it.

Then budget your energy like the limited thing it is. Put more into the people and plans that give something back and less into the ones that only take, so you're still going when you get near the goal.

> THE FIRST OF THE MONTH
>
> *You open your notes app. Of the four small things you tried, two have stuck and two quietly stopped somewhere around the second week. You still don't know why the Saturday swim fell away. You liked it. You write a question mark next to it for next month and close the app.*

You, in all your relationships

A goal for yourself usually touches the people around you, and small steps work everywhere. With a partner, offer one small habit rather than demanding one. With friends, one message a week can be enough to keep a friendship warm. In a family it might be a regular call, a visit you can actually keep up, or a first step after years apart (see Reaching out, spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts). At work it could be one comment per meeting, and with money, one small saving habit that's yours alone to keep.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

The self path, step by step

Sam, on their own, two weeks in

The path, step by step

Step	Where it's at
Check your battery	*Done ✓*

Step	Where it's at
Get to know your wiring	*Done ✓*
See where your lens came from	*Done ✓*
Plan what settles you	Not yet
Find words for what you feel	Not yet
Practise kind ways to say no	Not yet

Come back gently, once a week

Pick a day and a time, and add a ten-minute reminder to your own calendar. It repeats every week and just says "10 minutes for me".

Day	Time
Sunday	*7:30 pm*

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

The next step is Plan what settles you: the Calm-Down Kit. Three steps done is three steps done; the rest will still be here next week.

Fill in your own: The self path

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Reaching out
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
The self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Common mix-ups

"A goal has to be big to count" is the commonest, and the least true. Small and repeatable is what survives a bad week, and most

big goals turn out to be a lot of small ones in a trench coat. Some people think that once they know themselves they ought to be able to change anything, but wiring stays, so the aim is a goal that fits how you're built. Asking for support doesn't mean you couldn't manage alone. It gives other people the information they need to help. And "I'll start on Monday" isn't always a dodge, since a fresh start can genuinely help, but today's tiny version counts too.

> **A note on care:** This part is general education. It isn't therapy, coaching or medical advice, and it can't promise any result. Goals about your health, money, work or a hard stretch in life may deserve a qualified professional, and there's no shame in asking for one. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared. If a goal ever starts to feel like a weight, you can shrink it or put it down.

To start, write two plain words for what matters to you, one small goal as something you'll do, the tiniest first step you can think of and one if-then. Then put a ten-minute look-back in the calendar for a month from now. Your self-discovery path and Ten-minute start are free on the site.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Your self-discovery path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



TOOL
Ten-minute start
spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Start with what matters to you.
- ✓ Name what gets in the way.
- ✓ Decide ahead with a simple if-then.
- ✓ Look back kindly once a month.
- ✓ Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2, Chapter 7 · Values, meaning and a good life — Heal and Steady, page 121
Finding out what matters to you

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change — Heal and Steady, page 105
Why tiny steps and if-then plans work

Book 4, Chapter 5 · The monthly look-back — Share the Load, page 95
The same monthly look, done together

Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion — page 81
A kinder inner voice when a step slips

PUT IT TO USE

The self path, step by step
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

The Calm-Down Kit: a plan for heated moments
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next-in-depth

4

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 4

How feelings work: signals, the body, and naming what you feel

What feelings are for, where they start, and why putting a name to one can make it easier to carry, whether you're on your own, at home, with friends or at work.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A feeling is a signal, not a verdict
2. Feelings start in the body
3. Naming a feeling helps you hold it
4. More words, better tools
5. Feelings come in layers
6. Feelings rise and pass like waves
7. Feelings spread between people
8. If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings
9. Feeling it isn't the same as doing it
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

THURSDAY, 4:50PM

A message from your manager: "Have you got a minute tomorrow?" No full stop, no smiley, nothing else. Your stomach drops. By the time you get home you've snapped at the cat, skipped dinner and replayed every mistake of the last month, including one from March that nobody else remembers, although nobody has said anything bad at all.

Feelings sit underneath almost everything else in this book, from how we talk to how we handle stress. This chapter looks at how

they work first, and then at what to do with them. Two tools elsewhere lean on it. My weather today and the daily check-in (Chapter 2, page 25; Book 3, Chapter 1, page 9) ask for one word about how you are, because naming a feeling turns its volume down a little and a daily word catches feelings while they're small. And Say it so it lands (Book 4, Chapter 4, page 73) asks you to describe a feeling, because "I felt let down" is a great deal easier to hear than "you never care."

01

A feeling is a signal, not a verdict.

Feelings are fast messages about what matters to you. Fear warns that something might be dangerous. Anger says something seems unfair, or in your way. Sadness says you've lost something that mattered. A signal is worth listening to, but it can be wrong about the details, the way a smoke alarm goes off for burnt toast with exactly the same urgency it would use for a fire.

Say you feel jealous when a friend makes a new close friend. The jealousy proves nothing about you, and nothing about whether your friend is drifting off. What it shows is how much the friendship matters to you, which is worth knowing, and possibly worth telling her.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
>
> "This feeling is telling me something matters. What is it?" "Is this the fire, or the toast?"

02

Feelings start in the body.

Often your body reacts before your mind has a word for what's going on: a racing heart, a hot face, a heavy chest, a knot in the stomach. Then the brain tries to make sense of the signal, and it

guesses. That's why being hungry or tired or in pain can feel so like being upset.

A teenager comes home furious with his mum over very little, something about a towel. After a cheese sandwich and twenty minutes on the sofa with the dog, most of the fury has gone, and he admits, with some reluctance, that he skipped lunch. A few times today, stop and ask what your body feels like right now. Is there hunger in it, or cold, or a sore back?

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

My weather today

Esme, 29, at 4:50pm, after "Got a minute tomorrow?" from her manager

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · *Coworkers*

Someone I care for · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day

Too much noise or light · *Running on caffeine* · Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · *About enough* · Properly rested

People load

Barely any · *A normal amount* · A lot · Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · *One conversation* · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · Rest · To move · *To be heard* · *A plan* · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Talk window
wait about 20 minutes

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for deciding anything about another person.

The ground underneath: you haven't eaten in a while and you're running on caffeine. That isn't a side note. It's likely a big part of why today feels the way it does, and it's easier to change than character is.

Blowing in: one conversation. Weather from one front tends to land on whoever is nearest, often someone who had nothing to do with it. Worth saying out loud before it does.

You said what would help is a plan and to be heard. Arrange that before anything else.

If you want to send someone a line: "I don't need it solved. I just need you to hear this for a few minutes first."

Esme ate something, then rang her sister to be heard. She didn't reply to the message until the morning.

Fill in your own: My weather today

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

03

Naming a feeling helps you hold it.

Putting a feeling into words can turn its volume down. In brain-scan research by Lieberman and colleagues (2007), simply putting a name to a feeling ("I feel scared") turned down the brain's alarm response. A name gives a big, cloudy rush some edges, so you can see it and talk about it and decide what to do.

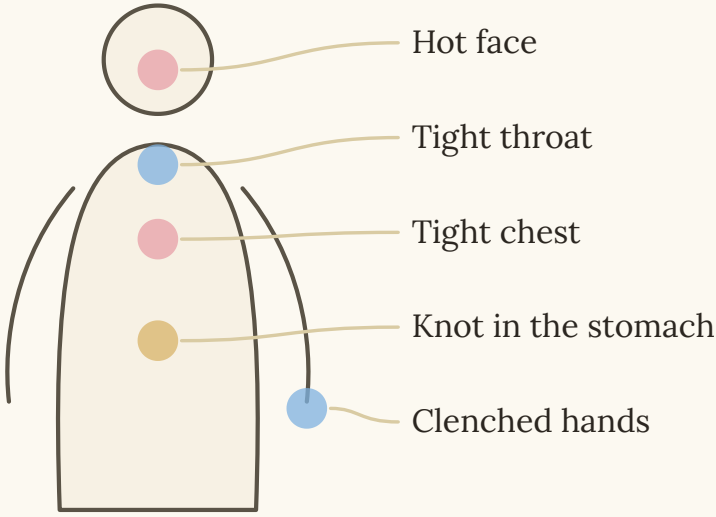
Two housemates are tense all evening, passing each other in the hall without a word. Eventually one says, "I think I'm embarrassed about the noise complaint, and I've been acting cross." The other, who had spent two hours wondering what she'd done wrong, puts the kettle on.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I think what I'm feeling is…" "I'm not sure what this is yet. Maybe worried?"

Once a day, name one feeling, out loud or on paper. A guess like "something like sad" still counts.

A feeling is a signal, not a verdict

It often shows up in the body before it has a word.



Feel it *in the body* → **Name it** *"I feel let down"* → **Choose** *what you do next*

It says: something here matters to me.
It doesn't say what to do.

Illustration. Everyone's body signals are a little different; these are common ones, not a medical map.

FIGURE 7 A feeling is a signal, not a verdict. It often shows up in the body first; naming it helps you choose what to do next.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If the words won't come, weather words often will. "Foggy" or "stormy" is a perfectly good place to start.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

04

More words, better tools.

"Bad" is a very blunt word. Disappointed is different from left out, and both are different from overwhelmed or ashamed; each points somewhere different and needs something different. A review by Kashdan, Barrett and McKnight (2015) found that people who can tell their feelings apart more finely tend to cope with them in healthier ways. You don't need fancy words. A number works, and so does a colour.

A dad tells his partner he feels bad about his mum, and they go round in circles for half an hour. Then he says, "Actually, I feel guilty that I haven't been up to see her since Easter, and scared she's getting worse," and within ten minutes they're looking at train times to Carlisle.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"On a scale of one to ten, I'm about a six." "It's less angry and more… let down." "It feels heavy, like a grey day."

05

Feelings come in layers.

The feeling you show first isn't always the one you felt first. Anger is very often a cover for hurt or fear, because anger feels stronger and safer to stand in. We also have feelings about our feelings, like being ashamed of being sad, and that second layer can sting more than the first.

A grandmother is curt with her daughter on the phone after the half-term visit is cancelled for the second time. Under the curtness is hurt. Under the hurt, if she let herself look, is a quieter fear that she isn't needed much any more. She doesn't say any of that. She says "Fine, well, another time," and then sits by the phone for a while. Next time you feel angry, ask yourself whether there's hurt or worry underneath. You don't have to tell anyone what you find.

06

Feelings rise and pass like waves.

Most feelings, even big ones, rise and peak and settle if you don't keep feeding them. Moods are another matter. A mood is more like weather, a background feeling that lasts hours or days and colours everything, often without you noticing it's there.

A woman who lives alone has a bad morning (the boiler, a bill, a dream about her ex) and by eleven has decided her whole life is going nowhere. By evening, after a walk along the canal and a long call with her sister, the same life looks ordinary and fairly okay, with a dentist's appointment on Tuesday and a library book she wants to finish. Nothing in her life changed between eleven and seven. That's a good reason to leave big decisions until the wave has passed: write the decision down and look at it again tomorrow.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
>
> "This is a wave. It will peak and pass." "Is this a feeling about now, or a mood colouring everything?"

07

Feelings spread between people.

We pick up each other's feelings from a tense voice, a sigh or a door shut a bit too hard, usually without noticing. That's part of how people bond. It also means stress can move round a home or a team like a cold in February.

A team leader comes into the Monday meeting rushed and anxious, and within ten minutes the whole team feels behind on everything. The next week she stops outside the door for two slow breaths before she goes in, and the meeting finishes on time, which in that office counts as a minor miracle. You can care about someone's feeling without catching all of it. Notice who you tend to catch feelings from, and before your next talk with them, give yourself one minute first.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
>
> "Is this feeling mine, or did I pick it up?" "I can stay beside their storm without standing in the middle of it."



TIDBIT

Good moods are catching too. If you'd like a small way to share one, there's a tool for it.

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding`

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Stay close: one small idea
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding`

08

If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings.

Lots of people grew up in homes, generations or cultures where feelings were kept private. "Don't make a fuss." "Big boys don't cry." "We don't talk about that." It's especially common among men and older people, and in some cultures keeping your feelings to yourself is a sign of respect and strength.

It isn't a flaw, and it doesn't mean you don't feel. Many people who rarely put a feeling into words show it every single day by doing things: fixing the tap, driving someone to the hospital at two in the morning, simply turning up. Caring by doing is real caring. Words can be added slowly, a few at a time, if you want them.

A retired builder whose wife has died has never talked about his feelings in his life. On the touchline at his grandson's Saturday match, during a dull bit of the first half, he says to his son, "I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her. Every morning." His son puts a hand on his shoulder, and they watch the second half together without saying much else.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her." "I'm not good with words for this. It's been a hard week." "I don't know what to call it. I just feel heavy." "I'm not one for talking, but I wanted you to know I'm proud of you."

If one of those fits, you could say it once this week, to one person or just out loud in the car. A text counts, and so does writing it down.

09

Feeling it isn't the same as doing it.

A feeling usually comes with an urge attached, to shout or run or hide or check or fix or text. You don't choose the feeling. You have rather more say over the urge. Pushing a feeling down tends to bring it back stronger, and acting on every urge can hurt people, so the workable middle is to let the feeling be there and choose the action.

A father hears glass go and looks out to see his son standing very still in the garden next to a football. He feels a hot rush of anger, says, "I'm too cross to talk right now. Let's sort this out in ten minutes," and goes to fetch the dustpan. If there's one urge you often act on too fast, like the sharp text, make yourself a rule to wait ten minutes before you send it.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "I'm feeling a lot right now. I'm going to take a minute before I answer." "I want to reply when I'm calmer."

> FRIDAY, 9:05AM
>
> *The knot is there again, and this time you name it. You're scared you're in trouble. So you go and ask your manager straight away whether today's chat is anything to worry about, and she looks genuinely surprised and says it's about the summer rota. You go back to your desk and eat the breakfast you skipped, a slightly squashed banana.*

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

“I don’t know how I feel”

FROM OUTSIDE Asked how they feel, someone says “I don’t know” and seems stuck.

THE LOGIC Feelings start as signals in the body → Some people find those signals hard to read → With no clear signal there is no clear word → So “I don’t know” is the honest answer

IT’S LIKE A radio caught between two stations.

WHY IT FITS Finding feelings hard to name is common, and it is more common among autistic people.

THE OTHER SIDE The person asking may feel shut out, or think something is being hidden from them.

YOU COULD SAY *“I really don’t know yet. Ask me about my body instead.”*

ONE SMALL STEP Try simpler questions, such as “More tired or more tense?” and “Space or company?”

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=dont-know-feeling

In everyday life

If you live on your own, there’s nobody to notice how you are, so a one-word check-in with yourself each day matters more (see On my own, spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own). With a partner, “What are you feeling?” can sound like a test you might fail, while “Do you want to tell me, or shall I just sit with you?” is much easier to answer. Children learn feeling words from the adults around them, and hearing you say “I’m frustrated, so I’m taking a breath” teaches them more than any lesson would. At work, a short “I’m a bit flat today, and I’m not upset with anyone” can stop a whole team guessing. And if someone close to you shows care by doing, say by clearing the drive on a bad day, you can thank them for it in words. They may not know what to do with it the first time.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

Some feelings are painful and some actions are harmful, but a feeling in itself isn't bad; it's information. Feeling stupid doesn't make you stupid either. Treat a feeling as a signal to check before you obey it. Lots of people expect to be able to name what they feel straight away, and plenty can't, some of them most days, which is why body words and numbers count as answers here. The last one is the most stubborn. We think a face tells us what someone feels, but faces are a poor guide. People show the same feeling in very different ways, and asking is both kinder and more accurate than guessing.

If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you name it for them. "You're angry" can land like a label, while "You seem upset. Am I reading that right?" leaves room for them to correct you. Then help the feeling make sense ("Of course you're upset, that was a lot"), which helps more than advice and doesn't mean you agree with everything they did. Offer a choice between ideas and just listening; a lot of people only want the second, and are relieved to be asked. Accept other ways of saying it, like a number, a text, a drawing or "I'm at a seven". And settle yourself first. If their sadness makes you anxious, calm down

before you go to them, so they don't end up looking after your feelings as well as their own.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "That sounds really hard." "Do you want to talk, or would company help more?" "You don't have to find the right word. A number is fine."

When to get more help

Everyone has hard days and big feelings. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or another trained professional if:

- a low, numb, anxious or angry feeling stays most days for two weeks or more;
- feelings are stopping you from sleeping, eating, working or seeing people;
- you are using alcohol, drugs or other things to stop feeling;
- you feel you can't cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. If that's happening now, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line straight away. You deserve help today.

If you feel afraid of someone you live with or are close to, that fear is an important signal. It is not something to "manage" on your own. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy. It can't know your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/safety

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers pages you fill in, on your own or together

- The Calm-Down Kit: a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Tools helpers you use on the website

- My weather today: a short, private daily check of your mood and state.
- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

More for your situation

- Chapter 2: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 25)
- Wired differently and Neurodivergent relationships
- For teens: when feelings get loud
- For caregivers: resentment and guilt
- Grief and later life
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Wired differently
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
For teens: when feelings get loud
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
For caregivers: resentment and guilt
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **A feeling is a signal** that something matters to you. It doesn't tell you what to do about it.
- ✓ **Feelings start in the body.** A tight chest or a hot face often arrives before the word for it.
- ✓ **Naming helps.** "I feel let down" is easier to hold than a big, nameless rush.
- ✓ **You can let a feeling be there** and still choose what you do next.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words — page 25
Reading your own weather day to day

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles — Share the Load, page 51
Feelings when a stress tank is full

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system — Heal and Steady, page 9
What the body does under pressure

Book 2, Chapter 2 · Anger — Heal and Steady, page 29
One feeling up close

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

My weather today
A short, private daily check of your mood and state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings-in-depth

5

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 5

Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

Why your worth isn't a score you keep earning, how shame differs from guilt, and why being kind to yourself makes it easier to grow.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Your worth isn't a score
2. Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."
3. Shame makes you want to hide
4. The inner critic is trying to protect you
5. Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off
6. Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you
7. You can own a mistake without drowning in it
8. Worth is learned between people, and we can give it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

THURSDAY, 11:20PM

You sent the wrong file to the whole team, last quarter's figures instead of this one's. Priyanka spotted it within four minutes, sent the right one round and said "no worries!" with an exclamation mark. Hours later you're still awake and replaying it, and the voice in your head has moved on from the file altogether. It's telling you that you're useless, and that everyone knows it now.

This chapter is about how self-worth and shame work, and then about what you can do with them, on your own, at home, with friends or at work. None of it is a diagnosis. Take what helps.

01

Your worth isn't a score.

A lot of us carry a quiet scoreboard. We're worth something when we're useful, or liked, or slim, or busy, or top of the class, or never any bother. Psychologists call these "conditions of worth", and the trouble with them is that any score can drop. If your worth goes up and down with each day's results, every bad day feels like a verdict on you as a person.

Pam taught Year 4 for forty years. In the September after she retires she feels lost in a way she can't explain to anyone, wandering round the big Tesco at ten on a weekday morning. Nothing is wrong. For four decades being needed was how she knew she mattered, and the bell has stopped ringing. Try finishing the line "I feel okay about myself when I…" three times, and look at what you wrote; those are your scores. Noticing them is plenty for now.

02

Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."

Guilt is about something you did, so it points somewhere useful: say sorry, put it right. Shame is about who you are, which feels impossible to fix, and so it makes people hide, freeze, blame someone else or lash out. Research on the two feelings, such as June Tangney and Ronda Dearing's (2002), suggests guilt is the one more likely to lead to repair.

A twelve-year-old knocks his mum's favourite mug off the side, the one with the hare on it from Whitby. Guilt tells him to own up and offer some of his birthday money towards a new one. Shame tells

him he ruins everything, and he wraps the pieces in yesterday's newspaper and pushes them to the bottom of the kitchen bin. So next time you feel bad about something, ask which one it is. If it has turned into who you are, try to shrink it back to the one thing you did, and then ask what would make that thing right.

03

Shame makes you want to hide.

You feel shame in the body before you think it: a hot face, eyes down, a sinking stomach, the wish for the floor to open. It can also come out sideways as sudden anger or a closed, cold face, which is how a small comment starts a big fight. In a meeting someone asks, mildly enough, "Didn't we already cover this?" and his colleague snaps back at him. That evening she realises the snap had nothing to do with the question; she had felt stupid in front of everyone.

It helps to learn your own shame signs. Next time you suddenly want to disappear, or to bite, you can name it quietly to yourself, and sometimes say it out loud: "I think I felt embarrassed just then, and it came out sharp. Can I try again?"

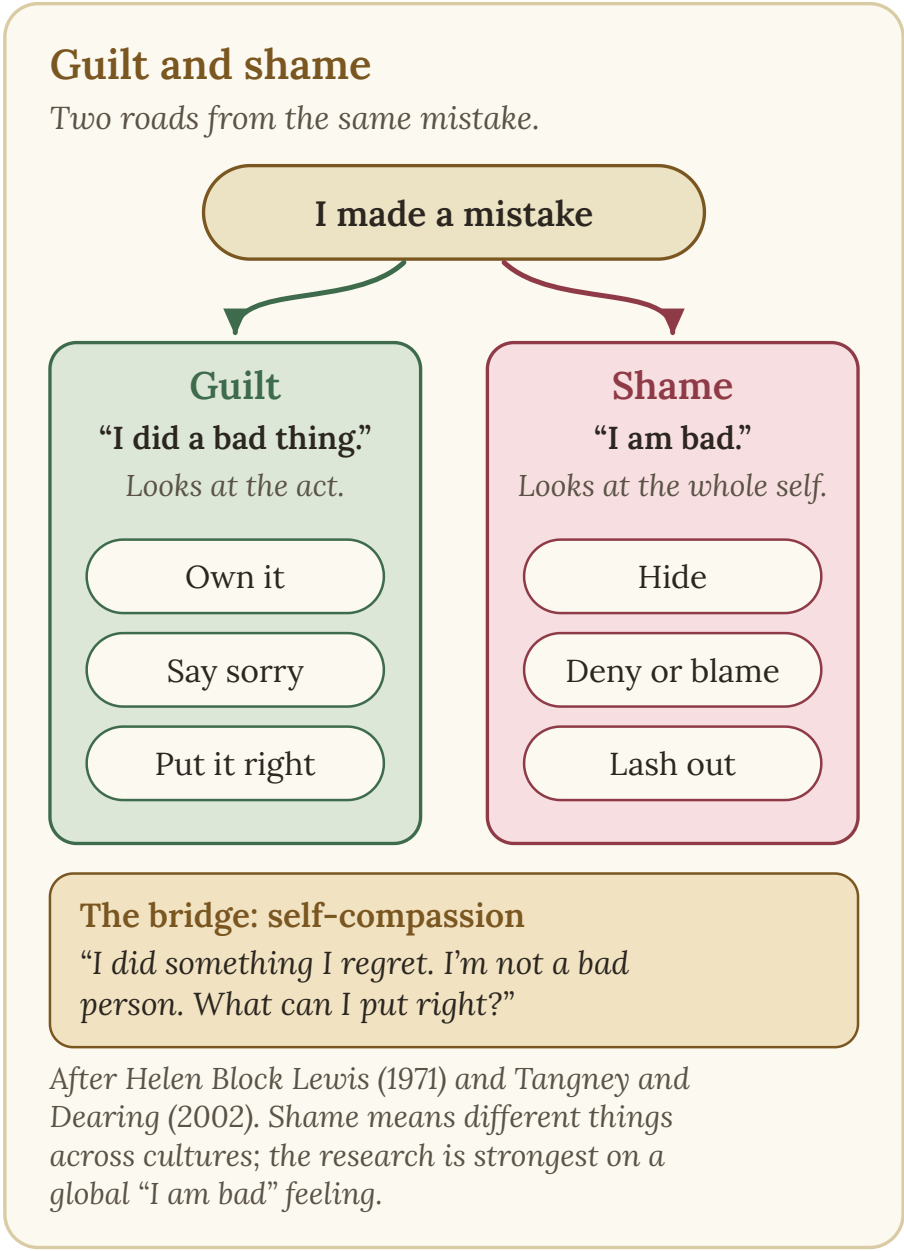


FIGURE 8 Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad." Guilt is easier to put right, and self-compassion helps you cross over.

04

The inner critic is trying to protect you.

That harsh inner voice usually started as protection. If you criticise yourself first, perhaps nobody else can get in a blow. If you're hard enough on yourself, perhaps you'll never fail again. It meant well. But a voice that only threatens keeps your body on alert, and it's exhausting to live with.

A young dad calls himself an idiot every time he forgets something for the baby, the wipes, the rabbit she won't sleep without. It's the word his own father used about him. The voice he hears in the car park at the nursery is an old one, borrowed years ago and never given back. Write down one thing your critic says often and ask whether you'd say it to a friend you love. Some people find it helps to answer the critic directly: "Thanks for trying to protect me. I can take it from here."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Flip it

Hamish, 44, after a mistake at work

Flip it

What's on your mind?

I got the figures wrong in the client report and my manager had to fix it. I'm hopeless at this job.

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone · A worry · *Being hard on myself* · Anger

THE FLIP

What a good friend might say
"That sounds like a hard moment. One mistake is not the whole of you. You're not hopeless. You're a person having a hard day."

Kinder words for yourself
"I had a hard moment. I'm human. Next time I'll [one thing]."

One next step
[one small thing, like a short sorry, a reminder on your phone, or some rest]

Talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a friend is a simple form of self-compassion. Being harsh rarely makes the next try easier. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Hamish's own words, after changing the flip
I got two figures wrong and it was caught before the client saw it. I'm human. Next time I'll ask a colleague to check the numbers before it goes out.

His next step
Send my manager a two-line sorry and the checking plan, today, then go home on time.

The flip is a starting point: Hamish changed the words until they were true and sounded like him.

Fill in your own: Flip it

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Small wins: Flip it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

05

Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.

Self-compassion means treating yourself the way you'd treat a good friend who's struggling. One well-known model has three parts: kindness in place of attack, remembering that everyone struggles, and noticing the pain without drowning in it. Studies, such as one by Juliana Breines and Serena Chen (2012), suggest that people who are kind to themselves after a failure are often *more* likely to try to improve.

Lindy fails her driving test for the third time, on the reverse round a corner again. In the test centre car park she tells herself that this is hard, that loads of people need more goes, and that she'll practise that one manoeuvre on the industrial estate on Sunday mornings when it's empty. Then she books another lesson. If it feels okay, put a hand on your chest or arm once today and say, slowly, "This is a hard moment. Other people feel this too. What do I need right now?"



SUGARFOOT

Speak to yourself the way you'd speak to a friend having a hard day, slowly and kindly. Writing it down first helps.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/write-it-through

06

Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.

Everyone measures themselves against other people; it's how we work out where we stand. Feeds full of other people's best moments make the measuring wildly unfair, though, and self-esteem that depends on being better than others swings about a great deal.

Two old friends meet for a curry, one with a new house, the other renting a room in a shared flat. The renter spends the whole evening quietly ranking herself and misses what's in front of her, which is that her friend is lonely in the new house and had wanted to talk about it. When you catch yourself comparing today, try swapping it for a question about the other person, like "How are you, really?" You're comparing your inside with their outside, after all.

07

You can own a mistake without drowning in it.

Owning a mistake gets much easier once it doesn't mean you're worthless. A simple shape helps. Say what you did, say what it did to the other person, say what you'll do now, and stop. Beating yourself up afterwards proves nothing about how sorry you are; it just moves the attention back to you.

A housemate forgot to pay her share of the broadband and it was cut off for the whole of a bank holiday weekend. She tells the others, "I forgot to pay, and that left you without internet all weekend. I've paid it and set a reminder for the 28th," and that's the end of it. Think of one small thing you still feel bad about and write your own three-part sentence. Then decide whether to send it or let it rest.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Owning a mistake can be short and plain: what happened, that it was yours, what you'll do. If it went wrong in a talk, Rewind the talk helps you find the words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

08

Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

Children learn their worth from how they're treated, and adults never quite stop learning it. The words matter. "You did a careless thing" leaves room to change, while "you're so careless" shuts the door. Praise for effort and for who someone is, as well as for results, helps people feel they matter on bad days too.

A team lead starts every project review by asking what the team learned rather than who got it wrong. Within six months, people are raising problems in week two instead of week ten, which saves everyone a great deal of Friday evening. Today you could say one thing to someone that has nothing to do with their results, even just "I'm glad I know you."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control how other people judge you, or what you were taught about your worth growing up. You can control how you speak to yourself now, whether you repair what you can, and where you spend your time. Give your energy to people who treat you as someone who matters. More in Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

FRIDAY, 9:15AM

You send one line to the team, sorry for the mix-up with yesterday's file, right one attached. When the old voice starts up you answer it the way you'd answer a friend: you made a mistake and you fixed it, which is what a decent colleague does. Priyanka replies with a thumbs-up. Nobody mentions the file again, and by lunchtime you've mostly stopped thinking about it too.

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Saying sorry all the time

FROM OUTSIDE Someone apologises for asking a question, for being in the way, for taking up room.

THE LOGIC An early apology can head off someone else's anger → The habit was often learned long ago, somewhere it kept things calm → The sorry works like a shield → So it is often about safety more than guilt

IT'S LIKE Ducking before anything has been thrown.

WHY IT FITS The habit made sense where it was learned, even if today is safe.

THE OTHER SIDE Constant apologies can sound hollow, or make the listener feel they must have been harsh.

YOU COULD SAY *"Sorry is an old habit of mine. I'm learning I don't need it here."*

ONE SMALL STEP Swap one sorry a day for a thank you. "Thanks for waiting" works where "Sorry I'm late" used to.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=sorry-a-lot

In everyday life

Shame turns up in very ordinary places. Between partners, "You forgot to call" can land as "You're a terrible partner", and so the reply comes out as a defence instead of a sorry. A child who hears "You're so naughty" learns something about who they are, while "That was a naughty thing to do" leaves them a way back. A friend who says yes to everything may be quietly burning out, because saying no feels like risking being dropped. At work, someone may sit on a small error for weeks because owning it feels like proof they don't belong there.

On your own: a kinder voice to keep

You don't need anyone else to start this. Notice how you talk to yourself and practise one gentler sentence. Catch the critic's favourite words ("always", "useless", "pathetic", "should") and swap one of them for a plain fact, so "I'm hopeless" becomes "I was late twice this week." On hard days keep a short list of what you did well, or simply did, and let getting up count. You're allowed to be disappointed in what you did and still be on your own side.

Common mix-ups

People worry that self-compassion is self-pity. They feel different from the inside: self-pity says "only me, poor me", while self-compassion says "this is hard, and other people go through it too", which connects you to others rather than shutting you off. Others fear that being kind to themselves will make them lazy. The research leans the other way, because fear of your own attack is what makes people avoid trying and hide mistakes. And self-worth doesn't mean thinking you're great. It means you matter on the days you aren't.

If you want to help someone else with this

Talk about what happened, never about what kind of person they are. Arguing with someone's shame ("You're not useless!") can feel like being told they're wrong to feel it, so try "It sounds like you feel really low about it. I don't see you that way." Helping them find one small thing they can do gives the feeling somewhere to go. And kindness on ordinary days, when nothing has gone wrong, teaches worth better than anything said in a crisis.

YOU COULD SAY

"That sounds like it's weighing on you. Want to work out one thing that would help?" "You don't have to earn being cared about."

When to get more help

Everyone feels shame and self-doubt sometimes. It's worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if harsh thoughts about yourself are there most days, if they stop you working, eating, sleeping or seeing people, or if you feel you deserve to be hurt. Therapies such as compassion-focused therapy and cognitive behavioural therapy are built to help with exactly this.

If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself or not wanting to be here, please tell someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

If someone close to you keeps telling you you're worthless, stupid or lucky to have them, that isn't a self-esteem problem. It can be a way of controlling someone. Signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) and Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) have free, private help.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Signs to look out for · Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? for a feeling that is too big to think through
- Ask Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



TOOL
Ask Professor Puddles
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

More for your situation

- **On your own:** Chapter 1: where you came from (page 9) · Your self-discovery path · On my own after a breakup
- **Teens:** For teens: feelings
- **Neurodivergent:** Wired differently · Neurodivergent relationships
- **At work:** At work

- **Coming out:** Coming out as an adult
- **Carers and parents:** Caring for someone you love · When a child has ADHD
- **Related chapters:** Loss, grief and big life changes (Book 2, Chapter 4, page 69) · Minds that work differently (Chapter 7, page 117)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Your self-discovery path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

ONLINE
On my own after a breakup
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
For teens: feelings
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
Wired differently
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Coming out as an adult
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out

ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Your worth isn't a score.
- ✓ Shame makes you want to hide.
- ✓ Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.
- ✓ Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.
- ✓ Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from page 9
Old rules that taught you your worth

Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming page 47
Kindness when a goal slips

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt Heal and Steady, page 85
Guilt, apology and forgiveness

Book 2, Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma Heal and Steady, page 49
When the inner critic gets loud

PUT IT TO USE

Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
For a feeling that is too big to think through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Ask Professor Puddles
The site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth-in-depth

6

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 6

Personality, temperament and change across life

What personality is, where temperament comes in, how people change across their lives, and how to live and work with people who are made differently from you, without putting anyone in a box.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Traits work like dials
2. Temperament is the starting point
3. Situations matter too
4. Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people
5. People change across life
6. You can change on purpose, a little at a time
7. Every trait has gifts and costs
8. Differences are usually about fit
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Traits work like dials.** Everyone sits somewhere along each one, and most people are near the middle.
- **Temperament is a starting point.** Babies already differ in how active, cautious or easily upset they are, and what happens next matters too.
- **People keep changing.** On average people grow steadier and more organised as they get older, and you can change on purpose, slowly.

- **Most clashes between personalities are about fit**, and nobody has to be at fault.

SATURDAY, 3:00PM

It's your aunt's seventieth in the function room above the cricket club, and you're standing quietly by the cake when she announces, loud enough for the whole room, that you were always the shy one. Everyone laughs. You smile along while something stings. You're forty-two. You stand in front of thirty children every weekday morning at twenty to nine. So are you still the shy one? Were you ever?

We describe each other by personality all the time (laid-back, a worrier, the organised one) and descriptions like those have a way of hardening into boxes. This chapter is about how personality actually works, and what stays put and what moves. Two tools elsewhere build on it: the "How to talk to me" card and the style quiz (Chapter 2, page 25) describe how you lean on a few dials, which is more use than knowing which box someone put you in, and One owner per job (Book 4, Chapter 2, page 27) arranges the jobs around people's differences so nobody has to become someone else to share a home.

01

Traits work like dials.

Personality is the usual pattern in how you think and feel and act. Many psychologists describe it with five broad traits, often called the "Big Five": **openness** (curious about new ideas and experiences), **conscientiousness** (organised and careful), **extraversion** (drawn to people and busy places), **agreeableness**

(warm and cooperative) and **emotional stability** (how steady your moods are).

The same five turned up in work such as McCrae and Costa (1987), whether people rated themselves or were rated by people who knew them well. Each one runs from low to high, and most people sit somewhere near the middle of most of them. That's the bit the online quizzes tend to leave out. Two friends do one on a train and get told, with great confidence, that one is an introvert and the other an extravert; when they look at the actual scores, they're four points apart and both near the middle. If you're curious, mark where you think you sit on each dial from one to ten, then ask where a close friend would put you. The gap is often the interesting part.

02

Temperament is the starting point.

Temperament is the part of personality you can see from very early on. Some babies are very active and some are calm. Some settle easily into new routines and some take their time. Some react strongly to noise or change. In their long-running study, Thomas and Chess (1977) described these early differences and the idea of "goodness of fit", meaning how well a child's temperament fits what the people and places around them expect of it.

A toddler who is slow to warm up cries at every new playgroup. Her mum stops trying to coax her into the circle and lets her watch from her lap for ten minutes instead, a bit awkwardly, in a church hall that smells of squash. By the third week the little girl climbs down on her own and goes to the sand table.

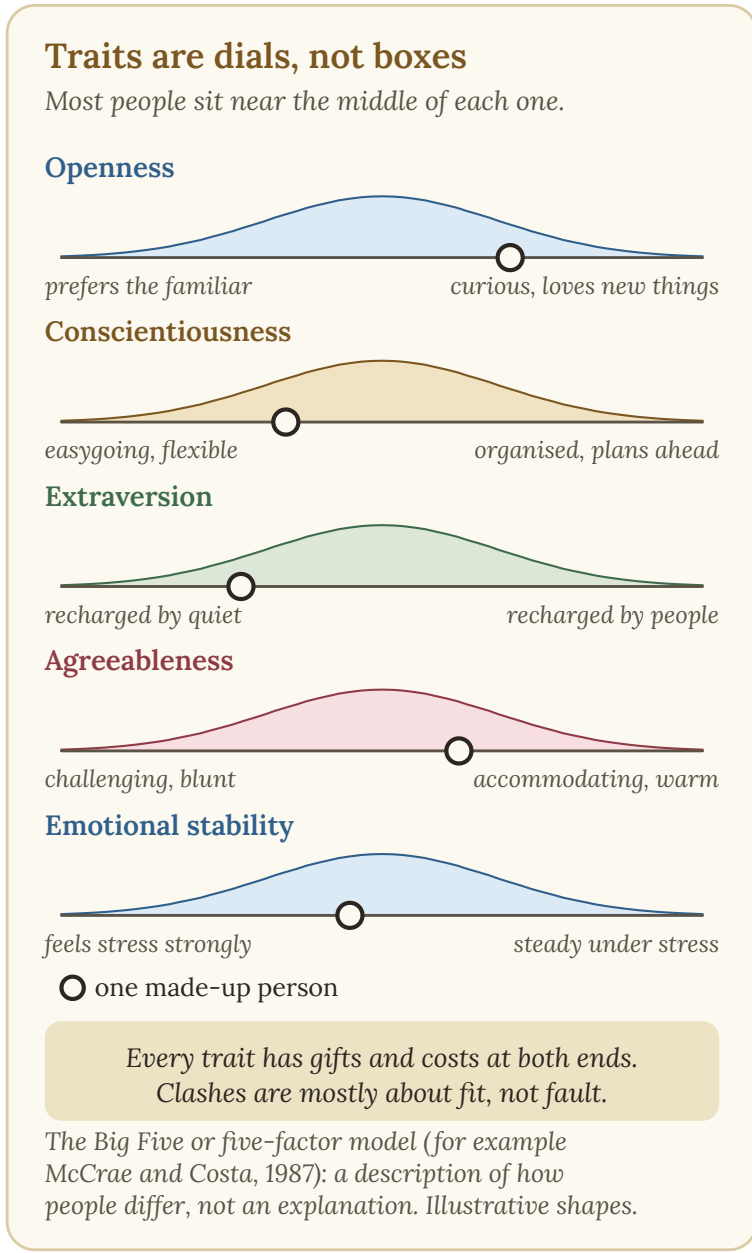


FIGURE 9 Traits work like dials, and most people sit near the middle of each. Illustrative shapes.

YOU COULD SAY

"You like to watch first. That's fine. Join in when you're ready."
(to yourself) "I need time to warm up. That's how I'm made."

03

Situations matter too.

Personality describes a pattern, and patterns have exceptions. The same person can be loud with family and quiet at work, or endlessly patient with toddlers and very short with call centres. A trait tells you what someone tends to do across lots of situations. It tells you much less about this one.

A manager decides that a new colleague is cold. Then at the team's charity football match she watches the same colleague in a borrowed bib, chatty, shouting encouragement at the goalkeeper, and on Monday she sits looking at the open-plan office wondering how much of what she'd seen was the room. Before you decide what someone is "like", try to see them somewhere else, or at least ask them about somewhere else.

04

Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people.

People who are more introverted often like people very much. What they find is that busy, noisy social time uses up energy, and they need quiet afterwards to get it back. People who are more extraverted tend to be topped up by company and busy places. Most of us are a mix, sometimes called an ambivert, and every point on the dial just needs different things to feel at its best.

At about eleven at a wedding in a barn near Hexham, one partner wants to go on to the after-party in the village pub and the other wants bed and silence. So one goes for an hour and the other walks

back to the hotel, and they meet at breakfast, one of them a bit hoarse, both of them happy.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

“I loved tonight, and I’m out of social energy.” “Shall we go together, and I’ll head home at ten?”



TIDBIT

Some people recharge in a busy park and some under a quiet blanket. Both are fine. A short quiz can show you your own style.

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

05

People change across life.

Personality is fairly stable. It also moves. A large review by Roberts, Walton and Viechtbauer (2006) found that, on average, people become more organised, more emotionally steady and more confident with others as they move through adult life, with much of the change between 20 and 40. A later review by Bleidorn and colleagues (2022) found that emotional steadiness went on growing right across the lifespan. Big life events play a part, and so do the roles people take on and who they love.

A man who was a nervous, disorganised student, the one who lost his keys every fortnight, is a calm, steady nurse in his forties, and his old school friends barely recognise him at the reunion. When they ask, he says that life kept asking him to cope and he slowly learned how. Write down one way you've changed in the last ten years, and what helped it happen.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
> "Who I was at fifteen isn't who I have to be now." "People I knew years ago may have changed too."

06

You can change on purpose, a little at a time.

If you want to change a trait, you can, slowly, mostly by acting differently in small ways again and again. In a study by Hudson and Fraley (2015), people who set goals to change one of their traits tended to move in the direction they wanted over sixteen weeks. A review by Roberts and colleagues (2017) found that therapy was often linked to lasting change too, especially towards more emotional steadiness.

A woman who wants to be less shy at work makes one small plan: say one thing in each team meeting, even if it's only agreeing with someone. For the first fortnight her heart pounds every time. After two months speaking up has become ordinary, and she has started to forget it was ever a plan. Pick one small action that fits who you'd like to be more of, like replying to messages the same day or saying hello first, and do it three times this week. Book 2, Chapter 6 (page 105) has more on habits.

07

Every trait has gifts and costs.

There's no good personality. Each trait helps in some places and gets in the way in others. Very agreeable people are kind and easy to be with, and may find no almost impossible to say. Very conscientious people are the ones you'd trust with your keys, and they may struggle to rest. People high in openness love new things and can be bored rigid by routine.

A very organised woman spends most of a year irritated by her relaxed housemate, his trainers in the hall and his "it'll be fine". Then the boiler packs in on the coldest night in January, and he's the one who stays calm, finds an emergency plumber at ten o'clock and makes everyone hot water bottles from the kettle. Pick one trait of yours that people sometimes complain about, and write down a time it helped.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"What is the gift in this trait, and what is the cost?" "What they do that annoys me might be the flip side of something I value."



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Every trait has gifts and costs. Writing down what helps you on a one-page card turns a "flaw" into useful information.

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

08

Differences are usually about fit.

When two people with different personalities share a home or a family or a job, friction is normal. A tidy person and a relaxed one can both be right in their own way, and so can a planner and someone spontaneous, or a talker and someone who needs quiet. What helps is naming the difference and agreeing how to live with it, without either of you being the problem. Personality is also different from neurodivergence and from mental health conditions; if something feels bigger than personality, Chapter 7 (page 117) may help.

A couple argue about every single holiday, because one wants every hour planned and the other wants to wander about and see what happens. This year they plan the mornings and leave the afternoons free. They still argue about the mornings. I'd count that as progress.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "I think we're just made differently here. What would work for both of us?" "I'm a planner and you're not. Can we plan half and leave half?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

How you connect: the style quiz

Mo, before moving in with his friend Callum

The style quiz: just my Wave Code

Twelve quick either/or taps, about two minutes.

Your first name (optional)

Mo

Someone asks you a big question. You…

Answer right away and figure it out as I talk

Need a moment, or a day, to think first

A sudden change of plans feels…

Fine, maybe even fun Jarring. I need a heads-up or a transition

Starting something new, you want…

The why and the big vision The first concrete step

When something bothers you, you usually…

Say it plainly so we can fix it *Hint at it, or wait for the right moment*

Someone says "I'm fine." You…

Believe them. Fine means fine *Check their tone to see if they really are*

…and seven more like these.

MO'S FOUR LEANINGS (HIS WAVE CODE: S F N A)

What each letter means
Pace: leans Slow Simmer (S, not Quick Spark) · Lens: leans Forest (F, not Trees) · Sending: leans Nuanced (N, not Direct) · Receiving: strongly Attuned (A, not Explicit)

The nickname the tool gives it: the Willow
Reflective and soft-spoken. Feels the undercurrents of every room.

Watch for
agreeing in the moment just to fill the silence; your real needs getting lost in the cushioning.

Mo's style-quiz statement: "About how I'm wired: I think first and talk second, I tend to hint rather than say it straight, I see the big picture first, and I like to take my time."

A Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, each a lean along a dial, not a type or a box. "Leans" means near the middle. Answers can change with the day, the setting and the person you're with.

Fill in your own: How you connect

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can get to know your own mix, look after what you need, and practise one small change if you want to. You can't change someone else's personality, and you don't have to change yours to be loved. If you're always the one bending to fit, it's fair to say so. Know your own wiring

SATURDAY, 5:30PM

As people start to drift off with foil-wrapped slices of cake, you think about sitting down next to your aunt and telling her about the thirty children. In the end you help clear the plates and say nothing. On the drive home you're still turning it over, half annoyed with her and half with yourself. You wonder whether she'll say it again at Christmas, and what you would like to say back if she does.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Know your own wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Eating the same lunch every day

FROM OUTSIDE The same sandwich, every day, for years.

THE LOGIC Every new food is a small gamble → A known food is a sure thing → Sure things save energy for the rest of the day → So sameness is a way of being efficient

IT'S LIKE A pilot's checklist, the same each time on purpose.

WHY IT FITS For people with strong senses of taste and texture, a known food takes away an unpleasant surprise.

THE OTHER SIDE The cook may feel their food is being turned down.

YOU COULD SAY *"It's safe and easy for me. It says nothing about your cooking."*

ONE SMALL STEP Keep one safe option on the table beside anything new.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=same-food

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing your own mix helps you build a life that suits you, with about the right amount of company and quiet. "I'm just not a people person" might be true, or it might be an old label worth testing at least once. With a partner, a shared plan (one of you does the bills, the other the holidays) usually works better than trying to change each other. A quiet friend who hardly texts may still care a great deal, so ask what kind of contact suits them. A child's temperament says nothing about good or bad parenting, and adjusting to fit them is a skill you learn. And family roles like "the clever one" or "the difficult one" can stick long after they stop fitting. You're allowed to grow out of them, even if your aunt hasn't noticed.

Common mix-ups

You aren't simply an introvert or an extravert. Most people are somewhere in the middle, and where you sit can shift with the setting and your mood. Personality isn't set in stone by adulthood either; it keeps moving slowly across the whole of life. Online type quizzes are good for fun and conversation, and that includes the website's own Wave Code, which shows four leanings on four dials, but they sort people into a handful of types when real people are spread along each dial. "They're just difficult" often means "they're different from me", and it can hide stress or illness or a need nobody has asked about. And practising something new isn't being fake. It feels unnatural at first, the way new shoes do, and becomes part of you over time.

If you want to help someone else with this

Drop the old labels. Notice if you still describe someone the way they were years ago, and look for who they are now. Ask instead of guessing: "What helps you recharge?" or "How do you like to plan things?" will tell you more than any theory about their personality. Notice growth out loud, because "You handled that so calmly" can show someone a change they hadn't spotted in themselves. And describe the action rather than the person. "You're so uptight" or "You're just lazy" closes doors that a plain description of what happened would leave open.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "I used to think of you as the shy one. I don't think that fits any more." "What do you need to be at your best this week?"

When to get more help

Personality differences are normal and don't need fixing. It may be worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or psychologist if:

- a pattern in how you feel, think or relate to people keeps causing you or others real distress, across many parts of life;
- you feel very unsure who you are, or your moods swing so much it's hard to cope;
- worry, low mood or fear of people is stopping you from living the life you want.

Please don't diagnose yourself or anyone else with a "personality disorder" from what you read online. Those are clinical terms that only a qualified professional can use, after a proper assessment.

A personality trait never excuses controlling, frightening or hurtful behaviour. If you're afraid of someone close to you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- How you connect: four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four

preferences, not a type.

- Communication style quiz.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

ONLINE
Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

More for your situation

- Chapter 2: your wiring, your weather and your words (page 25)
- Book 2, Chapter 6: Habits and change (page 105)
- Chapter 7: Minds that work differently (page 117)
- For parents · For teens · For grandparents
- Sharing a room · At work
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
For parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
For grandparents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents

TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room



TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words page 25
Your wiring today

Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from page 9
Temperament and how you grew up

Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently page 117
Minds that work differently

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change Heal and Steady, page 105
How change really happens

PUT IT TO USE

How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
Four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-14-personality-in-depth

7

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 7

Minds that work differently

How autistic, ADHD, sensory and learning differences work, why none of them is a character flaw, and how people with different minds can meet in the middle.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Brains vary, like bodies do
2. Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting
3. ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it
4. Everyone has a sensory profile
5. Learning differences aren't about intelligence
6. Masking costs energy
7. Autistic burnout is more than being tired
8. Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices
9. Stimming helps, so let it be
10. Deep focus makes switching hard
11. Deep interests are a source of joy and rest
12. Meet in the middle, out loud
13. Labels are tools, and they belong to the person
14. Finding out later in life
15. Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own
16. When demands feel like a threat
17. Not recognising faces isn't rudeness
18. Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say
19. Telling friends and dates is your choice
20. Finding your people
21. In everyday life
22. Common mix-ups
23. If you want to help someone else with this
24. When to get more help
25. Tools and reading on this site
26. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Brains vary, like bodies do.** A different mind is not a broken one, though differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.

- **Nobody chooses overload.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.
- **Less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests and real rest** help a great deal.
- **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

MONDAY, 8:15AM

You ask him for the third time to just put his shoes on. Your son is lying on the hall floor with his hands over his ears, because the new socks feel wrong, and you're already late. To him the seam across his toes feels like sandpaper, and the alarm clock from the bedroom, which nobody has switched off, is still ringing inside his head.

This chapter is for neurodivergent people, diagnosed or not, and for the people who live and work with them. It explains how these minds work and then what helps. It can't diagnose anyone, and only you get to choose the words you use for yourself. I should say that some of it is personal: I'm autistic, with ADHD in the mix too, and the About page on the website tells that story. I've tried to write it the way I'd want it written about me.

Two tools elsewhere rest on it. The "How to talk to me" card (Chapter 2, page 25) works because different minds need different input, and saying things plainly helps almost everyone. One owner per job and the written job list (Book 4, Chapter 2, page 27) move memory out of anyone's head and onto paper, which helps ADHD and autistic minds most and everybody a bit.

01

Brains vary, like bodies do.

Brains differ in how they take in the world, focus, move, read, remember and connect with other people. “Neurodiversity” is the idea that this variety is natural. “Neurodivergent” describes people whose minds work differently from what gets treated as typical. A different mind isn’t a broken one. Differences can still be disabling, though, especially in a world built for one kind of mind, and both of those things are true at once.

A man who struggled all through school finds out at forty that he’s dyslexic. Mostly what he feels is relief, sitting in the car outside the assessment centre, because for thirty years he had half believed the teachers who called him lazy in red pen.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
> “Maybe this isn’t a flaw. Maybe it’s a difference that needs a different setup.”

02

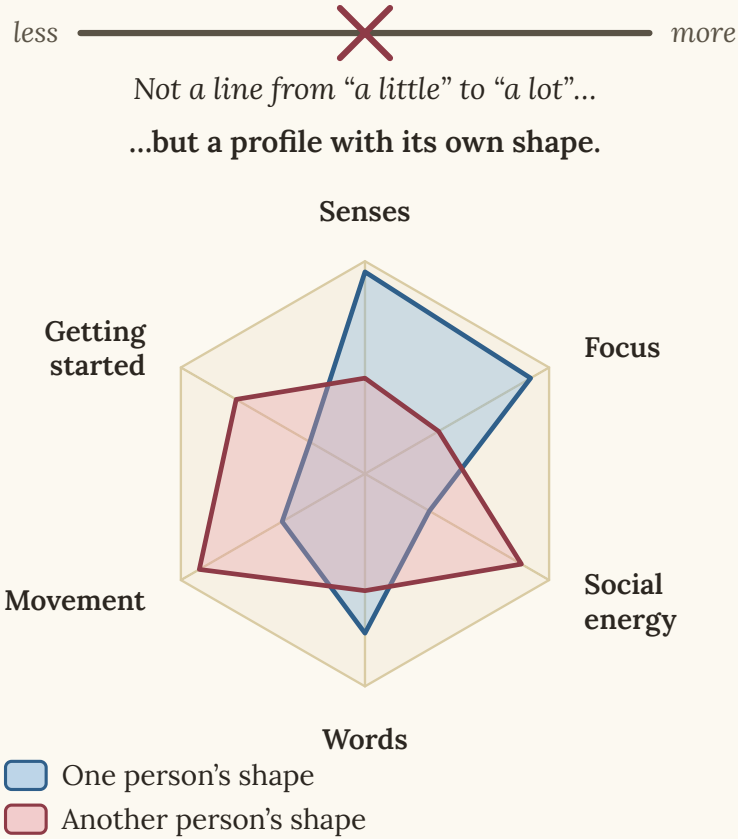
Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting.

Autistic people often communicate more directly and literally. Many have deep, focused interests, feel senses more (or less) intensely than others do, and find predictability calming. Autism doesn’t run along a single line from “mild” to “severe”. Each autistic person has their own mix of strengths and needs, which can change from day to day, and misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people usually run both ways.

An autistic analyst tells a colleague that his slides have three typos, one on slide four and two on the summary. She means it as help; it’s what she would want to be told. He hears criticism. They are using different rules for what kindness sounds like, and neither rule is wrong.

Brains vary, like bodies do

Different, not broken.



Strong in some places, stretched in others.
Ask what helps, and say what helps you.

Illustration, not a test. "Spiky profile" is a common way to describe uneven strengths and needs.

FIGURE 10 Brains vary, like bodies do. A mind has a profile with its own shape, not a place on a line from "a little" to "a lot". Different, not broken.

YOU COULD SAY

"I like it when people say exactly what they mean. You can be direct with me." "Do you want my honest view, or just support right now?"

03

ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it.

People with ADHD often have plenty of attention. The hard part is pointing it where they choose. Boring tasks can feel impossible while interesting ones swallow whole evenings, time can feel slippery (there's "now" and there's "not now"), and feelings can arrive fast and big. It's a real difference in how the brain manages itself, and it has nothing to do with effort or care.

A woman with ADHD forgets her best friend's birthday entirely, then spends six hours making her a card with pressed flowers from the garden, glued on with tweezers. The forgetting and the six hours come from the same brain. If something keeps falling out of your head, move it into the world: an alarm with a label, a note on the door, a basket by the exit.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I care about this. My brain drops things. A reminder really helps, and it doesn't annoy me."

04

Everyone has a sensory profile.

We all take in sound, light, touch, smell, taste, movement and signals from inside the body. Some people feel these strongly and get overloaded by noise or a scratchy label. Others need more input, like movement, strong flavours or firm pressure. Overload is a body at its limit, which is a very different thing from being fussy.

Two housemates fall out over the kitchen radio, because one finds silence eerie and the other finds Radio 2 at breakfast physically painful. They settle on the radio in the mornings until nine and headphones after that, and the arrangement has lasted two years. Notice one sound, light or texture that drains you and one that calms you, and change one small thing today.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Knowing your own sensory profile is useful information, not a complaint. A one-page card lets you share what helps, in your own words.

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

05

Learning differences aren't about intelligence.

Dyslexia (reading and spelling), dyscalculia (numbers), dyspraxia (coordination and planning movement) and language disorders are specific differences, and none of them measures how clever someone is. Plenty of people have a "spiky" profile, very strong in some areas and struggling in others. The right tools can level the ground a good deal: audiobooks, say, or extra time.

A fourteen-year-old with dyspraxia is called clumsy on the football pitch every Wednesday afternoon, and in the same term he writes

and directs the school play. Ask someone you live or work with how they find it easiest to take in information, and then use that.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I learn better when I can listen than when I read. Could you send a voice note instead?"

06

Masking costs energy.

Many neurodivergent people learn to hide their differences: copying others, forcing eye contact, holding back movements, rehearsing small talk in the car. This is called masking. It can get someone through a day. It also uses a great deal of energy, and over years it can wear a person down into exhaustion and burnout. I masked for a long time, and the cost was invisible to everyone but me, which is rather the point of a mask.

A student seems completely fine all day at college, chatty in the canteen, helpful in class. She gets home, goes straight to her room, and can't speak for an hour while she recovers from a day of performing. Notice one place where you can drop the mask a little, and one person you can be fully yourself with, and spend a bit more time there.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I need some quiet time after work. It's how I recharge, and I'm not upset with you."

07

Autistic burnout is more than being tired.

Autistic burnout is a deep, long-lasting exhaustion. Working with autistic adults, Raymaker and colleagues (2020) described it as long-term exhaustion, loss of skills (like speech, planning or self-

care) and lower tolerance of noise, light and other input. It comes from long stress without enough support, and it often lasts months. Rest helps, and so do fewer demands and less masking. Pushing harder usually makes it worse. If you think you might be there, list three demands you could drop or hand to someone else for a month. If it goes on, or you feel hopeless, talk to a doctor.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> "I'm in burnout. What I need for a while is fewer demands." "I can't do phone calls at the moment. Can we message instead?"

08

Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices.

A **meltdown** is an involuntary loss of control when overwhelm gets too much, and it can look like crying, shouting, running off or lashing out. A **shutdown** is the quiet version: going still, losing speech, not being able to respond. Neither is a tantrum. In interviews by Phung and colleagues (2021), autistic young people described meltdowns and shutdowns as separate experiences, both linked to overload. What helps is less of everything, so less noise, fewer words, fewer questions, and more space and safety. Talking can wait, sometimes until the next day. On a calm day, agree a simple signal for "I'm overloaded" and a quiet place to go.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> (to someone else) "You're safe. I'm right here. No need to talk."
> (for yourself) "I'm overloaded. I need quiet for twenty minutes."

09

Stimming helps, so let it be.

Stimming means repeated movements or sounds, like rocking, flapping, tapping, humming, pacing or fiddling with something. Most people stim a little. (Watch any meeting and count the

jiggling feet.) For many autistic people it matters a lot. In interviews by Kapp and colleagues (2019), autistic adults described stimming as a way to cope with overwhelming emotions and sensations, and objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming. If it isn't hurting anyone, it doesn't need stopping. It's worth noticing what your own hands do when you're stressed or focused or happy, because that's yours.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "Rocking helps me think. It doesn't mean anything's wrong."
> "You don't need to stop. It's fine with me."

10

Deep focus makes switching hard.

Some minds, often autistic and ADHD ones, go deep into one thing at a time. That focus can be a real gift. It brings real expertise, and a lot of joy. It also makes switching hard. Being interrupted can feel like being pulled out of water, and a warning before a change helps enormously.

A dad calls his daughter down to dinner three times and gets crosser each time; the fish fingers are going cold. The next evening he gives her a ten-minute warning and then a five, and she comes to the table on time, still talking about the castle she's building and the problem with the drawbridge.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Dinner is in ten minutes. I'll come and get you at five to." "Can you give me a warning before we switch?"

11

Deep interests are a source of joy and rest.

Many autistic people have deep, intense interests, often called special interests. The theory of monotropism (Murray, Lesser and Lawson, 2005) describes autistic attention as pulled strongly into a few things at a time. In a survey of autistic adults by Grove and colleagues (2018), people who were more motivated by and engaged with their special interests reported higher wellbeing, though very intense engagement went with lower wellbeing. Ask someone about their favourite subject and let them talk for five minutes without steering. It costs you five minutes, and it's one of the warmest things you can do.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "Can I tell you about this for five minutes? It's how I unwind."
> "Tell me more. What's the best bit?"



TIDBIT

The website can change to fit your mind too, with bigger text, calmer pages and fewer surprises. The settings are worth a look.

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Read your way
spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

12

Meet in the middle, out loud.

When two kinds of mind live or work together, neither should have to do all the adjusting. Clear, explicit words help everyone: say what you mean, give times, write things down, ask what helps. And changes made for one person (a quiet space, a written agenda, flexible hours) usually help a lot of other people too.

A team starts sending meeting agendas a day early for one autistic colleague. Within a month most of the team say the meetings have got shorter, and two people who never spoke in them have started to. Today, swap one "how I work best" fact with someone: tell them one thing that helps you, and ask for one that helps them.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"What would make this easier for you?" "Here's what helps me. What helps you?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

"How to talk to me" card, for work

Tom, autistic, for his new manager

Your card

Who it's for

A partner Family A friend *Work (a manager or coworker)*

Name on the card, optional

Tom

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
A written list.

I take words
Literally.

Give me time to answer
Write it down so I can answer later.

Please avoid
A hard topic with no warning. Correcting me in public.

A request lands best as
"Could you ___ by ___?"

Also good to know about me
If I go quiet, I'm processing, not upset. Tell me the plan, and tell me if it changes. Noise, light or touch can wear me out.

Sensory needs
Short breaks in long talks.

Sent with one line: "Here's a short card about how I work best. It's not a request for anything big; it just helps us avoid crossed wires."

Sharing a card is always the person's own choice.

Fill in your own: "How to talk to me" card

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

13

Labels are tools, and they belong to the person.

A diagnosis can bring understanding, and sometimes support and a community too. Some people find their way to a label through self-discovery first. Many autistic adults prefer "autistic person"; others prefer "person with autism." The kindest rule is to ask, use the words the person chooses, and never try to diagnose somebody else, least of all in an argument.

During a row about the washing-up, a man tells his partner, "You're so autistic." It lands as an insult and ends the conversation. The next morning, over toast, he apologises and asks what his partner actually needs from him, which is the conversation they should have had the night before. If you've wondered about yourself, write down what you've noticed and choose one small next step, like talking to someone or asking a doctor.

> WORDS TO TRY
>
> "How do you like to describe yourself?" "I'm wondering if I might be neurodivergent. I'd like to find out more."

14

Finding out later in life.

More and more adults are finding out they're autistic, or have ADHD, in their thirties, fifties or seventies. Many were missed as children, especially women. In interviews by Leedham and colleagues (2020), women diagnosed at forty or older described how exhausting it had been to go so long without an explanation, and how much the diagnosis changed the way they understood their own lives. Relief and grief and joy can all turn up together, in the same afternoon. If that's you, look for one autistic-led group or online space, and give yourself time.

YOU COULD SAY

"I've just found out I'm autistic. I'm still working out what it means." "That explains so much about my life."

15

Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own.

Planning, starting, switching, remembering what you were doing and keeping track of time are called **executive function**. Many autistic and ADHD people find some of these harder, and harder on some days than others. A review of 235 studies by Demetriou and colleagues (2018) found differences in executive function in autism on average, with a lot of variation between people. The brain's self-management system is working differently. Laziness doesn't come into it.

A woman can write a brilliant forty-page report for her board but cannot, for three weeks, get herself to post one parcel. Once the parcel sits by the front door with a yellow sticky note on it and a phone alarm set for Tuesday at 8.10, it goes on Tuesday. Pick one task that keeps not happening and make the first step tiny and visible. See routines that help and Wired differently.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"Could you send me that as a list? Spoken steps fall out of my head." "I'm not ignoring it. Starting is the hard bit for me."

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
routines that help
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids



ONLINE
Wired differently
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently

16

When demands feel like a threat.

Some people, often autistic, feel strong anxiety when asked or expected to do things, even things they want to do. Avoiding the demand can look like refusing, joking, changing the subject or a meltdown. The profile was first described as "pathological demand avoidance," or PDA, by Newson and colleagues (2003).

It isn't in the main diagnostic manuals, and researchers disagree about it. A review by Kildahl and colleagues (2021) found the evidence limited and mostly based on parent reports. Many people who identify with it prefer the phrase "persistent drive for autonomy." Whatever it's called, what helps tends to be the same: less pressure, and requests that feel like invitations. A boy who digs in at "Put your coat on now" puts it on quite happily when his dad says, "It's cold out. Coat or jumper, your choice."

> WAYS TO SAY IT
>
> "I wonder if we could…" "No rush. Which would you rather?" (for yourself) "Being told makes it harder. Can I choose when?"

17

Not recognising faces isn't rudeness.

Prosopagnosia, or face blindness, means finding it hard to recognise faces, sometimes even close friends seen out of context. It can be something you're born with, and it often runs in families (NHS). Many autistic people also find remembering faces harder, as a review by Weigelt and colleagues (2012) found. People who don't recognise you may be relying on your voice, your hair, your coat or where they usually see you.

A man walks straight past his neighbour in the big Sainsbury's without a word, and she goes home feeling snubbed. When he explains later that he didn't recognise her without her spaniel, she

starts saying hello first, with her name, and they get on better than they did before.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'm bad with faces, so please say who you are when you say hi." (to someone else) "Hi, it's Jo from next door."

18

Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say.

Some autistic people speak rarely, sometimes or not at all, and some lose speech when stressed. Many communicate through **AAC** (augmentative and alternative communication), which can mean typing, letter boards, picture cards, apps or sign. Using AAC doesn't stop speech developing: a review by Millar, Light and Schlosser (2006) found it did not hold speech back, and may help it. The safest place to start is to presume competence, which means assuming the person understands and has something to say, and giving them the time and the tools to say it.

At a family Sunday lunch, a non-speaking teenager types on her tablet. Her uncle used to talk about her across the table as if she weren't there. Now he waits for her reply and answers her, a bit slower than he'd like, which is fine. Wait longer than feels natural. It will feel very long. It isn't.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "Take your time. I'll wait." "Would you rather type or point?" (for yourself) "I can't talk right now. I can type."

19

Telling friends and dates is your choice.

Whether to tell someone you're autistic or ADHD, and when, is up to you. Telling can bring understanding. In a study by Sasson and Morrison (2019), people formed better first impressions of autistic adults when they knew they were autistic, especially if they knew more about autism.

People don't always respond well, though, and interviews by Au-Yeung and colleagues (2025) describe autistic adults weighing hope for support against fear of not being believed. Many share a little at a time, starting with what helps and leaving the label for later. On a second date, a woman says, "I'm autistic, so I'm pretty direct, and I'd rather walk than sit in a loud bar." Her date admits he hates loud bars too, and they walk along the canal as far as the lock and back.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "I'm autistic. For me that means…" "I won't always pick up hints, so please just tell me." (if someone shares with you) "Thanks for telling me. What helps?"

20

Finding your people.

Lots of autistic people describe meeting other autistic people as a turning point, because at last they don't have to translate or explain or mask. The research backs this up. Cooper, Smith and Russell (2017) found that autistic people who felt more connected to other autistic people had higher self-esteem, and through that, less anxiety and depression. Being autistic can be an identity and a community as well as a diagnosis.

After a late diagnosis, a man joins an online group of autistic adults who love old maps, the Ordnance Survey kind with the hand-

drawn hachures. For the first time in years a long conversation leaves him with energy to spare.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"There are people who work like me." "I can belong somewhere without masking."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't change how your brain, or anyone else's, is wired. You can learn how yours works and say what helps, and ask others what helps them. Meeting in the middle means both people move a little. If you're always the one adjusting, it's fair to say so. More in Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

MONDAY, 8:30AM

You stop asking and sit down on the hall floor next to him. "Socks feel wrong?" He nods. You go and switch off the alarm clock still beeping in the bedroom, fetch the old seamless pair from the wash basket, and two minutes later his shoes are on. You're ten minutes late and nobody has shouted. That evening you order three more pairs of seamless socks and let him choose the colours.

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Wearing headphones at the dinner table

FROM OUTSIDE At a family meal, one person has headphones in.

THE LOGIC Sound arrives whether you want it or not → A brain that filters less hears all of it at once → Filtering by hand uses up attention → Headphones do the filtering, so there is attention left for people

IT'S LIKE Sunglasses on a bright day. You still see everything, without squinting.

WHY IT FITS Many people take in more of the background noise. One theory links this to how much the brain smooths out what it hears.

THE OTHER SIDE The family may feel shut out of the meal.

YOU COULD SAY *"These help me stay at the table."*

ONE SMALL STEP Agree a tap on the arm that means "I'm talking to you", and take one ear out when it comes.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=headphones

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing how your mind works helps you build a life that fits it, and spot burnout before it's on top of you (see Get to know your wiring, spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path). Partners can swap "how I work best" notes about plans, messages, touch and time alone. With children, behaviour often has a sensory or overload reason, so "What's too much right now?" is worth asking before "Why are you doing this?" A friend who cancels at the last minute may just be out of energy, and offering something easier, like a walk, keeps the door open. At work, written agendas, clear deadlines and quiet spaces help far more people than the ones they were made for.

If you have ADHD and share a home, make the chore tools lighter. Log three days instead of seven, with a tally on the fridge. Own a few jobs completely, each with a labelled alarm, instead of helping a bit with everything. Forgetting is a setup problem to fix together. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Common mix-ups

"Everyone's a bit autistic" is probably the commonest of these. Everyone shares some traits, but autism is a whole pattern, present across life, and the phrase makes real needs sound small. ADHD doesn't just mean not sitting still; many people with it, girls and women especially, are mostly inattentive or restless on the inside. "They seem fine to me" overlooks how much masking can hide, and seeming fine can cost someone their whole evening. Adjustments aren't special treatment. They remove a barrier, the way glasses do. And the idea that autistic people lack empathy is simply out of date: many feel other people's feelings strongly, and the differences in how empathy is shown run both ways.

If you want to help someone else with this

Believe them about what's hard and what helps, even when it's different for you. Be clear: say what you mean, give times, write down anything important. Ask what helps, because every

neurodivergent person is different and their answer will beat any list, this one included. Protect their energy; quiet time, warnings before changes and a way out of loud places matter more than they look. And enjoy their interests. Listening to someone talk about what they love is about the warmest thing you can do for them.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "Is there anything about this place, or this plan, that would make it hard for you?" "You don't have to explain. Just tell me what you need."

When to get more help

If you wonder whether a difference is part of ongoing difficulties at school, work or home, for you or someone you care for, a doctor, school support staff or a psychologist can talk you through an assessment. Waiting lists can be long, so start early and write down what you notice.

Burnout, depression and anxiety are more common among neurodivergent people, often because of the stress of living in a world that doesn't fit. If you're exhausted most days, losing skills you used to have, or feeling hopeless, please talk to a doctor. **If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself,** please tell someone today.

In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

A difference never excuses harm, and it never makes someone deserve harm. If someone uses your differences to control or

belittle you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Communication style quiz for a friendly look at how you send and receive words

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

More for your situation

- **Couples:** Neurodivergent relationships
- **Parents and grandparents:** When a child has ADHD · Neurodivergent families
- **At work:** Neurodiversity at work · Autistic at work
- **Teens:** For teens

- **Sharing a home:** Sharing a room
- **On your own:** Get to know your wiring · Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)
- **Related chapters:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (Chapter 5, page 81) · Loss, grief and big life changes (Book 2, Chapter 4, page 69)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

FOR AUTISTIC READERS. If you are autistic, or wondering, several pieces were written with you in mind. Masking and autistic burnout are covered earlier in this chapter, and When feelings are hard to name (Chapter 2, page 31) looks at alexithymia. The double empathy problem explains why misunderstandings run both ways, the wiring card gives you a one-page "how I work best" card to share, and Autistic at work has words for asking for what you need.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships · Neurodivergent families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships



ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids



ONLINE
Neurodiversity at work · Autistic at work
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room



ONLINE
Get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship



ONLINE
The double empathy problem
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently



TOOL
How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words page 25
Getting to know your own wiring

Book 3, Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune Understanding Each Other, page 9
Pace, tone and meeting in the middle

Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change page 99
Dials, not boxes

Book 3, Chapter 2 · How communication works Understanding Each Other, page 25
Saying it so it lands for different minds

PUT IT TO USE



Communication style quiz
For a friendly look at how you send and receive words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

How you connect: how I like to be spoken to
A one-page "how I communicate" card to share
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth

Questions people ask

Some questions this book tends to raise, with short answers and where to read more.

Do I need to remember my childhood clearly for the first chapter to help?

Most people remember a handful of scenes and a general feeling, and that is plenty. The first chapter asks about the rules your home ran on, such as how feelings were handled or who did the worrying. Those rules tend to show up in how you react today more than in any one memory, so start with one rule you can name. Where your lens came from (Chapter 1, page 9) walks you through it.

What if looking back brings up something painful?

Stop there, and come back another day if you want to. Nobody has to finish a page. If old memories keep pulling you under, or you find yourself avoiding more and more of everyday life, talk to a doctor or counsellor. Worry, low mood and trauma (Book 2, Chapter 3, page 49) describes the kinds of help there are, and the help page at the front of this book (page 7) lists free places to start.

I think I might be autistic or have ADHD. Can this book tell me?

It can't, and nothing in it is a test. Minds that work differently (Chapter 7, page 117) describes how some minds work, so that you might recognise yourself or someone you love, and it says who can talk you through an assessment if you want one. Plenty of people find the descriptions useful whether or not they ever look for a diagnosis.

Can a grown-up really change their personality?

A little, slowly, and mostly by practising the thing you want to be more like. Personality, temperament and change (Chapter 6, page 99) treats traits as dials that move a few notches over the years. Every setting has its gifts and its costs, so the aim is a better fit with your life more than a new you.

My partner isn't interested in any of this. Is it still worth reading?

Yes. This book is about you, and it works if you are the only person in your home who ever opens it. Knowing your own wiring and weather makes it easier to say what you need, and the people around you often notice the change before they notice the book. If you later want to look at things together, Book 3 and Book 4 are written for that.

How do I know when a book isn't enough?

Most chapters have a short part called "When to get more help", with the signs to look out for. If you need someone now, the help page at the front of this book (page 7) has numbers to call. Help beyond this book lists counsellors, helplines and support groups, and most of them are free.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Help beyond this book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04

In: Who you are becoming (page 47)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), Who you are becoming (page 47), How feelings work (page 63)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 81)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 81)

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

In: How feelings work (page 63)

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

In: Where your lens came from (page 9), Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), Who you are becoming (page 47), Personality, temperament and change (page 99)

TOOL **How you connect: how I like to be spoken to** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), Personality, temperament and change (page 99), Minds that work differently (page 117)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

In: Where your lens came from (page 9)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: How feelings work (page 63), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 81)

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), How feelings work (page 63)

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 81)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 81)

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

In: Minds that work differently (page 117)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Who you are becoming (page 47)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting

In: Who you are becoming (page 47)

TOOL **Plan it once: room agreement for roommates** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

In: Who you are becoming (page 47), Personality, temperament and change (page 99), Minds that work differently (page 117)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 81), Personality, temperament and change (page 99), Minds that work differently (page 117)

TOOL **Ten-minute start** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes`
In: Who you are becoming (page 47)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Alexithymia
Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

A bid
A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

Calm-down plan
Your calm-down plan (once called the Calm-Down Kit) is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Carrier wave
The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Double empathy
The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

Frequency
Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

If-then plan
A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that", which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

The ladder
Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load
The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Masking

Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

Monotropism

A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Wave Code

Four letters from the style quiz in How you connect, one for each of four preferences about how you take in and send words. Each letter shows where you lean on a dial today: a shorthand for preferences, not a personality type.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring
Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper
A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

Your lens
Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes

The 108 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online:
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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A calm breathing game. A flower blooms with every slow breath, and there are fireflies to guide and a lily pond to fill.

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Spread Love & Acceptance is a series of short books. Each one stands on its own; read them in any order.

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Book 3	**Understanding Each Other** Pace and tone, how words land, how we see each other, belonging, love, groups and helping well.
Book 4	**Share the Load** For homes, families and teams: seeing the unseen work, one owner per job, and two kinds of fair.
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Pocket guide	**The Logic Behind It** Thirty-eight everyday reactions, one to a page, with the logic behind each one and a kind next step.

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Your notes

For what you want to remember, try or ask about.